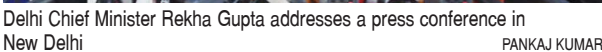


PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Addressing a press conference, the Chief Minister said the hike is aimed at benefiting the maximum number of needy people. The hike decision will be approved in the next cabinet meeting, she added. At present, the income

After taking office, the government audited the public distribution system and found significant irregularities. A total of 7,71,384 ineligible beneficiaries were identified. Of these, 6,46,123 were above the income limit, 95,682 had not

Ration distribution has been modernised through the use of electronic weighing machines and mandatory biometric authentication at fair-



Ration card services, including new applications and family member updates, are

now online. Citizens can apply from home or at facilitation centres. These steps aim to increase transparency and accountability and to ensure that only eligible households receive food security benefits. Earlier, officials accepted

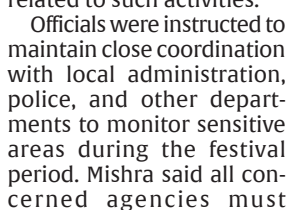
To curb corruption and irregularities, the government has implemented a robust digital and administrative verification mechanism. In the first stage, to address corruption and irregularities, the government has set up a digital and administrative verification process. Food and supply officers first review applications and documents and conduct field checks if

The chief minister said the annual family income eligibility limit for ration cards has already been increased. The annual family income eligibility limit for ration cards has been raised from ₹1 lakh to ₹1.20 lakh under the Delhi Food Security Rules, 2026, to

"For 13 years, the rights of Delhi's poor remained effectively locked away. Previous governments turned the ration system into a vehicle for politics and corruption. The process of issuing new ration cards had virtually come to a standstill-this deprived lakhs of deserving families of their rightful benefits. Our government is committed to replacing that system with a transparent and people-centric mechanism. Every eligible person should now receive their entitlement with dignity," the chief minister said.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
 New Delhi

During a review meeting with the Development Department, the minister instructed authorities to ensure complete compliance with laws related to animal protection and public hygiene during the festival. He said sacrifices should be permitted only at authorised and designated locations

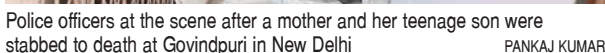


According to officials, the government also discussed the need for regular monitoring of designated sacrifice sites to ensure compliance with civic and environmental norms. Mishra referred to guidelines issued by the Animal Welfare Board of India to state governments and police authorities regarding the enforcement of animal protection laws during festivals.

KHUSHI MEHROTRA
 ■ New Delhi

According to Delhi Police, a PCR call regarding the inci-

The family consisted of Vishnu, his wife and their son, who occupied the ground floor of the four-storey house they allegedly owned, police sources said. Senior police officers,

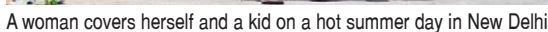


including the SHO and ACP, rushed to the spot and secured the crime scene. Crime and forensic science

laboratory teams inspected the house and collected material evidence from the scene of the crime.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
 New Delhi

The last time the minimum temperature was higher than this was on May 26, 2012,



West Bengal has become the first heatstroke patient to be admitted to Delhi's Dr Ram Manohar Lohia Hospital this

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

According to the report, the treated dis-

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
 New Delhi

Delhi Power Minister Ashish Sood stated that the government is considering the rising power demand as the city plans to adopt electric vehicles and expand its



In the next year, 'Mission 2030' aims to reduce the average number of power cuts from three to one per consumer annually. It also targets a reduction in the restoration time for supply from the current 45 minutes to 30 minutes, to decrease transformer breakdown rates from 0.53 per cent to 0.25 per cent, as detailed in the mission document.

Reliable energy for India's rising aspirations

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Sd/-
R. K. Jain
Director (Finance) & CFO
DIN: 08788595
Date: 21.05.2026
Place: New Delhi

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IN FOCUS



India's first Next Generation Offshore Patrol Vessel (NGOPV) Yard 3039 by Garden Reach Shipbuilders and Engineers (GRSE) Ltd, during its launch event in Kolkata on Wednesday

PTI

AI must be shaped by ethical oversight: Nadda

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Artificial Intelligence (AI) presents immense opportunities for advancing healthcare delivery, but it must be shaped by sound regulation, ethical oversight and a deep commitment to equity, Union Health Minister JP Nadda has said. Nadda made the remarks while addressing an event on 'Artificial Intelligence in Health: Laws, Ethical Oversight, Research and Equity' at the 79th World Health Assembly in Geneva.

"While AI presents immense opportunities for advancing healthcare delivery, it must be shaped by sound regulation, rigorous research, ethical oversight and a deep commitment to equity so its benefits reach every citizen," he said.

The minister said India laid a strong digital foundation over a decade ago under Prime Minister Narendra Modi through the launch of the Digital India initiative in 2015. He said the initiative was aimed at transforming India into a digitally empowered society and a knowledge economy, preparing the country for future technologies, including AI.

Nadda said India's National Health Policy of 2017 envisioned an integrated, interoperable, inclusive and scalable digital health ecosystem, which later led



to the launch of the Ayushman Bharat Digital Mission in 2021, along with consent-based digital health data frameworks.

He stressed that digitisation and data alone are insufficient to achieve better health outcomes, and sector-specific governance frameworks are essential for the safe and responsible deployment of AI.

He also highlighted the launch of the Strategy for AI in Healthcare for India (SAHI) during the India AI Impact Summit in February 2026.

Describing SAHI as the first comprehensive strategy emerging from the Global South, Nadda said it would guide India's healthcare journey in an ethical, transparent and people-centric manner. Nadda said the country is governing AI for 1.4 billion citizens across 22 official languages and varying levels of healthcare access.

Rajnath inaugurates Indian War memorial in Seoul

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh on Thursday highlighted the "enduring legacy" of India's contribution to peace and humanitarian assistance for the Korean Peninsula.

Singh, currently on a visit to Seoul, spoke about shared history of the two nations after inaugurating an Indian War memorial at Imjingak Park along with South Korea's Minister of Patriots and Veterans Affairs, Kwon Oh-eul. Constructed as part of the commemorative events marking the 75th anniversary of the Korean War, the memorial stands as a tribute to the courage, sacrifice and humanitarian service rendered by the 60 Para Field Ambulance of the Indian Army and the Custodian Force of India (CFI) during the war.

The two ministers laid a wreath at the memorial and paid homage to the brave Indian personnel whose service continued to be remembered with deep respect and gratitude by the people of the Republic of



Korea, according to the defence ministry.

In his remarks, Singh highlighted the enduring legacy of India's contribution to peace and humanitarian assistance on the Korean Peninsula, it said. He noted that the shared history and sacrifices of the two nations continue to serve as a strong foundation for the India-Republic of Korea Special Strategic partnership.

The defence minister added that commemorating the role of Indian troops helps strengthen people-to-people understanding and

remembrance of the selfless sacrifice of the soldiers.

The 60 Para Field Ambulance, commanded by Lt Col (Dr) AG Rangaraj, earned widespread recognition for its exemplary medical service and dedication in treating thousands of wounded soldiers and civilians under extremely challenging conditions, the ministry said in a statement.

Their unmatched bravery and humanitarian approach earned them the title of 'Maroon Angels', given to them by the wounded soldiers and civilian population of South Korea, it said.

India also played a pivotal role in the post-armistice phase of the Korean War through CFI, which was entrusted with the responsibilities under the Neutral Nations Repatriation Commission (NNRC).

The NNRC, chaired by India under the leadership of Lt Gen KS Thimayya, was established to facilitate the humane repatriation and custody of prisoners of war following the signing of the Korean Armistice Agreement in 1953, according to the ministry.

AI plane suffers tail strike at Bengaluru airport

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Thane

A Delhi-Bengaluru Air India flight, with 181 people on board, was grounded after it experienced a tail strike during landing at the Bengaluru airport on Thursday morning. The airline's narrow-body A321 aircraft was operating the flight AI2651 from Delhi to Bengaluru.

The Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) has begun its investigation into the matter. "The operating pilots have been off rostered pending investigation," DGCA sources said.

An Air India spokesperson said the plane "experienced a tail-strike during landing". The aircraft landed safely, and all passengers and crew disembarked normally, the spokesperson said. Due to the grounding of the aircraft, the return flight AI2652 from Bengaluru to Delhi has been cancelled.

A source said the plane experienced "wake turbulence" when it was close to land, following which the pilot decided to perform a go around manoeuvre. During the manoeuvre,



there was a tail strike, the source added.

The "wake turbulence" was caused due to the take-off of a wide-body aircraft in the vicinity, the source said. Specific details about the wide-body plane could not be ascertained. Wake turbulence is the disturbed, chaotic air trailing behind an aircraft. It is the disturbance generated by an aircraft that can affect encountering aircraft due to the strength, duration, and direction of the vortices.

The source said there were 181 passengers onboard the aircraft that operated the flight AI2651.

The Air India spokesperson said the plane has been grounded for detailed inspection and the incident will be investigated in accordance with established procedures, in coordination with the relevant regulatory authorities.

Lucknow division power block delays several trains

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Lucknow

In view of a six-hour traffic-cum-power block over the Lucknow Division, railway authorities have announced temporary changes in the operation of select trains, including rescheduling and regulation of services on specific dates.

According to the railway administration, the following train will remain temporarily rescheduled: Train No 22453 Lucknow-Meerut City Express, scheduled to commence journey on May 26 and June 2, 2026, will be rescheduled by 20 minutes from Lucknow station. In addition, the following trains will be regulated en route in the Moradabad Division: Train No 13308 Firozpur Cantt-Dhanbad Junction Express, journey commencing on May 25 and June 1, 2026, will be regulated for 45 minutes.

Illegal structures demolished at Garib Nagar near Bandra station

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Western Railway on Thursday said about 85 per cent of the nearly 500 illegal structures in Garib Nagar near Bandra station have been demolished as its drive to free the area of encroachments entered its third day.

The demolition process remained peaceful during the day and no law and order situation was reported, WR Chief Public Relations Officer Vineet Abhishek said.

About 85 per cent of the nearly 500 illegal structures in Garib Nagar near Bandra station have been demolished, he said.

"Around 13 machines and

several dumpers were deployed for the drive on the third day. The larger pucca structures had already been removed, while smaller and temporary structures were being dismantled manually," Abhishek said.

Authorities are handling the issue sensitively and had distributed food and water to personnel engaged in the drive as well as residents of Garib Nagar who approached them, he added.

"A total of 1,200 personnel, including security staff, remained deployed on the third day as well. Around 80 metric tonnes of debris had been removed from the demolition site on the second and third days with the help of 40 vehicles. The

cleared area would be fenced immediately after the removal of the illegal structures," the CPRO said.

Western Railway launched the demolition drive on Tuesday to remove around 500 unauthorised structures following the High Court's directive amid tight security arrangements.

However, the area witnessed stone-pelting on Wednesday, resulting in several policemen getting injured. Police had to resort to lathi-charge to restore normalcy.

It has led to the arrest of 16 persons, while police are scanning CCTV footage from the area to apprehend another 150 allegedly involved in the violence.



India and Egypt resolve to enhance anti-terror cooperation

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

India and Egypt called for concerted global efforts against all UN-designated terrorist entities and their affiliates, proxy groups, supporters, sponsors and



financiers.

Both sides reviewed a wide range of traditional and emerging threats and challenges such as terrorist recruitment, abuse of technology for terrorist purposes and financing of terrorism during a high-

level meeting held in New Delhi on Wednesday.

The two sides also agreed to bolster bilateral cooperation in combating the threat of terrorism.

"India and Egypt underscored the importance of bilateral cooperation in

countering terrorism, reflecting the spirit of India-Egypt Strategic Partnership," the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said on the India-Egypt Joint Working Group meeting on Counter-Terrorism.

PM tells Cabinet to deliver work faster

It is learnt that the PM took special briefing from the ministries of agriculture, forestry, labour, road transport, corporate affairs, external affairs, commerce and power. The discussions assumed added significance against the backdrop of growing global economic concerns arising from the intensifying West Asia conflict.

The meet also comes days after the Prime Minister urged people to reduce discretionary spending on fuel, gold and overseas travel. It brought in attendance union cabinet ministers, ministers of state with independent charge and other ministers of state.

Madrassas told to sing Vande Mataram daily...

State Congress leader Pradip Bhattacharjee called the Directorate of Madrasah Education's order incorrect.

Bhattacharjee said that making Vande Mataram mandatory in madrassas was not appropriate, noting its historical association with protest and political mobilization, political rallies and protests. The government could have consulted the teachers in the madrassas and allowed them to make the decision, he said.

Transport strike in Delhi-NCR begins quietly...

The cess on light commercial vehicles was raised from ₹1,400 to ₹2,000 from April 19, while charges for three-axle vehicles went up from ₹2,600 to ₹4,000, with a 5 percent annual hike built in going forward. Unions are also opposing the proposed ban on BS-4 and older commercial vehicles from entering Delhi-NCR from November 2026, arguing the restriction is based on vehicle registration category rather than actual tailpipe emissions.

The All India Motor Transport Congress (AITMC) has warned that if demands are not addressed, the three-day symbolic action could escalate into an indefinite shutdown. The Government has not announced any talks with the unions so far.

For now, Delhi has absorbed day one without significant disruption. Whether that holds through Friday and Saturday, with unions actively working to consolidate participation, is the question that commuters across the city will be watching closely when they step out tomorrow morning.

Pulwama attack linked terror operative shot...

Indian sources have suggested that covert operations by external actors may be involved.

The attack on Burhan is seen as a setback to the infrastructure supporting terrorism in J&K. Since the abrogation of Article 370, security forces have dismantled several terror modules, but individuals such as Burhan continued to operate.

27 Maoists surrender in Jharkhand

Welcoming the 27 surrendered Naxalites and their families, the DGP assured them that the Jharkhand Police would continue to support and care for them. She said all benefits and assistance promised under the Government's rehabilitation policy would be provided in a systematic and well-planned manner.

The surrender took place during a special ceremony held on Thursday morning at the Jharkhand Police Headquarters in Ranchi. According to officials, the success was achieved through a coordinated strategy involving the Jharkhand Police, CRPF and intelligence units. Sources said more than two dozen Maoists active in the Saranda region had been attempting to flee the forests over the past month, after which security agencies facilitated their safe exit and surrender.

Prominent Maoist leaders among the surrendered cadre include Gadi Munda alias Gulshan, Nagendra Munda alias Prabhat Munda, Rekha Munda alias Jayanti, Sagen Angaria alias Dokol, Karan Tiyyu, Darshan alias Binj Hansda, Suleman Hansda and Basumati Jerai. Several of them carried rewards of up to ₹5 lakh each.

Two JJWP members, Sachin Baik and Shruvan Gop, also surrendered before the authorities. Sachin Baik carried a reward of ₹5 lakh and was

wanted in multiple cases registered in the Gumla district.

The surrendered extremists also handed over a large cache of arms and ammunition to the police. The recovered weapons include one Light Machine Gun (LMG), five INSAS rifles, nine Self-Loading Rifles (SLRs), one bolt-action rifle, one pistol, 31 magazines and nearly 3,000 live cartridges.

Among those who surrendered are seven zonal commanders, seven area commanders and 13 active cadres. Police records show that a total of 426 cases related to Maoist activities have been registered against them.

Security agencies said the development reflects the weakening influence of Left-Wing Extremism in Jharkhand. Officials attributed the success to sustained anti-Naxal operations and the government's rehabilitation policy, which has encouraged several insurgents to return to the mainstream.

Jharkhand is fighting Naxalites, or CPI (Maoist) insurgents, through both security measures and development programs. The state's goal is to end left-wing extremism. Maoists once controlled 13 districts, but their influence has dropped. Now, Maoist activity is mostly limited to small areas in West Singhbhum.

Falta repolls peacefully

The Election Commission of India subsequently ordered a repoll in Falta even as results for the remaining 293 assembly constituencies had already been declared on May 4, with the BJP scripting a historic victory and coming to power in West Bengal for the first time.

Election officials said 86.11 per cent of the 2.36 lakh electorate had cast their votes till 5 pm, marginally lower than the 86.71 per cent recorded till the same hour in the original polling on April 29.

Reacting to the high turnout, Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari thanked the people of Falta and said visuals from the constituency resembled a festival.

"From the visuals, it appears people are taking part in a festival. Such a turnout in a repoll is really unprecedented," he said.

Khan's exit significantly altered the political arithmetic around Falta.

The BJP, already projecting confidence of an emphatic victory, sees the constituency as a

near-certain addition to its assembly tally after the TMC nominee stepped out of the contest before repolling.

If the BJP wins Falta, its tally for the 2026 Assembly polls would rise to 208, although operationally its Assembly strength would remain 207 following Adhikari's decision to vacate Nandigram after retaining Bhabanipur.

Around 35 companies of central forces guarded the 285 polling booths, while 30 Quick Response Teams remained on standby after the Election Commission significantly strengthened security arrangements for the repoll.

"For the first time in nearly 15 years, I feel I could vote peacefully. Earlier, many people felt they could not vote freely. This time, the atmosphere is different," a voter said, alleging that Jahangir Khan and his associates had exercised overwhelming influence in the area during previous elections.

Officially, six candidates remained in the fray, including BJP's Debanshu Panda, Congress candidate Abdur Razzak and CPI(M)'s Shambhu Kurmi.

Ebola scare delays India-Africa summit

In its statement, the MEA said India and the African Union exchanged views on the "evolving health situation" in parts of Africa and reaffirmed the importance of continued cooperation in strengthening public health preparedness and response capacities across the continent, including support for the Africa Centres for Disease Control and Prevention (Africa CDC) and national health institutions.

"Recognising the importance of ensuring the full participation and engagement of African leaders and stakeholders, and mindful of the emerging public health situation on the continent, consultations were held between the Government of India, the Chairperson of the African Union, and the African Union Commission regarding the holding of the summit and associated activities," the MEA said.

"Following these consultations, the two sides agreed that it would be advisable to convene the Fourth India-Africa Forum Summit at a later date," the statement added.

India reiterated its solidarity with African nations and expressed readiness to support

Africa CDC-led efforts in tackling the health crisis.

The upcoming summit was expected to provide a major boost to India-Africa relations and deepen cooperation in areas including trade, healthcare, infrastructure, capacity building, and development partnerships.

India's engagement with Africa has increasingly focused on African priorities and local ownership. Since 2018, New Delhi has expanded its diplomatic presence across the continent by opening 17 new missions, taking the total number of Indian diplomatic missions in Africa to 46. The last India-Africa Forum Summit was held in New Delhi in October 2015.

The health advisory, issued by the Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS), names the Democratic Republic of Congo, Uganda and South Sudan as "high-risk countries" following the World Health Organisation's (WHO) declaration of Ebola as a Public Health Emergency of International Concern (PHEIC).

The Airport Health Organisation (APHO) has displayed the advisory at Delhi airport, urging travellers to monitor symptoms such as fever, weakness, headache, muscle pain, vomiting, diarrhoea, sore throat and unexplained bleeding.

Passengers who had direct contact with the blood or body fluids of suspected or confirmed Ebola patients have been asked to immediately report to airport health officials.

According to APHO, travellers developing symptoms within 21 days of arrival should seek urgent medical attention and disclose their travel history to authorities.

Meanwhile, Union Health Secretary Punya Saila Srivastava chaired a high-level review meeting with health secretaries of all states and Union territories to assess preparedness and response measures.

Officials clarified that no Ebola case has been reported in India so far. However, the Centre has strengthened surveillance and precautionary measures nationwide to prevent any possible outbreak.

The government has already shared detailed Standard Operating Procedures (SOPs) with states and Union territories covering screening, quarantine, case management, referral systems and laboratory testing. Relevant ministries and departments have also been sensitised to step up preventive and surveillance efforts in coordination with the health ministry.

NEET row: Parliament panel grills NTA officials

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

At the backdrop of NEET 2026 paper leak and CBI probing the controversy, top NTA officials were summoned by a Parliamentary Standing Committee on Thursday, with the agency's director general telling the members that the NEET-UG paper was not leaked through their system and the CBI is probing the matter.

During a meeting of the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Education, Women, Children, Youth and Sports, several MPs questioned the National Testing Agency (NTA) officials on the steps taken by them to strengthen the exam system in order to prevent paper leaks in the future. The medical-entrance exam was cancelled recently amid allegations of paper leak. A re-test is scheduled to be held on June 21.

The panel had summoned top officials of the education ministry, including Education Secretary Vineet Joshi. The

NTA officials, including Chairperson Pradeep Kumar Joshi and Director General Abhishek Singh, gave a detailed presentation on the recommendations of the Radhakrishnan Report on reforms in the agency.

The sources said on queries from the MPs on how the National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test (Undergraduate) paper was leaked, Singh said it was not leaked through their system. At this, several MPs asked him then how did the paper get leaked and what was the need to cancel the exam and hold a retest. The NTA DG had no answer to this and instead, said the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) is looking into the matter.

Some opposition MPs demanded that the probe report be presented before the panel, but some of their counterparts from the ruling BJP objected to this, saying the CBI is an independent body and it should be allowed to do its work.

Sources said Singh gave a detailed presentation on the



Youth Congress members stage a protest over the alleged irregularities in the NEET-UG medical entrance exam, demanding accountability from the Central Government, at Freedom Park in Bengaluru, Karnataka on Thursday

implementation of the steps recommended by the Radhakrishnan Report on NTA reforms and informed that around 70 per cent of the short-term measures suggested have already been implemented.

The NTA officials told the members of the panel that steps are being taken to evolve a foolproof examination system and a compre-

hensive review is being conducted. They also said credible people should be involved in the paper setting and distribution system.

The NTA officials said holding the NEET through a computer-based testing (CBT) platform is being considered and future exams could be conducted through this mode.

The MPs are learnt to have

raised the issue of a shortage of staff and filling vacancies in the NTA to ensure that the agency functions efficiently and leakages are prevented.

Sources said the NTA informed the members of the committee that there is a staff shortage of around 25 per cent in the agency currently and steps are being taken systematically to fill up all such vacancies to plug

any loophole. After the meeting, the chairperson of the parliamentary panel, Congress MP Digvijaya Singh, said, "Whatever discussions happen in the parliamentary committee, we are under oath and we cannot discuss it."

"The meeting went off very well. We got inputs from all the members. The members expressed their concerns over the NEET paper leak," he said later briefing the media.

Earlier, listing out the steps taken by the NTA and the Government to prevent breaches and malpractices, the officials of the agency said detailed standard operating procedures (SOPs) and checklists for breach management in both PPT and CBT modes have been sent to stakeholders and the collaboration established with the state or district administrations for conducting high-stake examinations and reporting malpractices are being actively monitored on social-media platforms.

Union Minister to launch JEEVAN app, SHATAYU dashboard today



Union Minister Virendra Kumar

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Union Social Justice and Empowerment Minister Virendra Kumar will on Friday launch the JEEVAN mobile application for senior citizens and the SHATAYU dashboard for geriatric caregivers in a programme in which the ministry will host a virtual programme on "Creating a Well-Functioning Care Economy".

The virtual programme will focus on strengthening the country's care ecosystem through technology, community participation and policy interventions.

Department of Social Justice and Empowerment Secretary Sudhansh Pant will address the event, the ministry said in a statement.

Union Ministers of State for Social Justice and Empowerment BL Verma and Ramdas Athawale will also address participants.

The ministry said the care economy includes childcare, eldercare, disability support, health-related home care and domestic services, covering both unpaid household care work and paid care services delivered through formal and informal sectors.

PM making reels in Italy, while our youth tormented by paper leaks: Rahul

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Thursday attacked Prime Minister Narendra Modi over the NEET-UG paper leak and said he has neither taken responsibility nor sacked Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan.

In a post on X in Hindi, he said the Congress will not stop till Pradhan resigns and a robust system to prevent paper leaks is put in place. Taking a swipe at Modi,

he said while the prime minister was making reels in Italy, the youth of India were taking to the streets seeking justice over the paper leak.

"When Modi ji was making reels while handing out candies in Italy — youth in India, tormented by paper leaks, were taking to the streets demanding justice," he said in his post.

"Because the NEET Paper Leak has ruined the futures of lakhs of students. Many children have even lost their lives. And Modi ji neither



took responsibility, nor removed Dharmendra Pradhan, nor uttered a single word," he said.

With students, NSUI and INC workers seeking justice, BJP's state Governments are 'raining lathis' down on

them, the leader of opposition in Lok Sabha said.

"A Government that answers students' questions with batons doesn't run on accountability — it runs on fear. But we will not be scared. We won't stop until Dharmendra Pradhan resigns and a strong, secure system is put in place to stop paper leaks in the country," Gandhi said.

This fight, the former Congress chief said, is for every such student whose future this "failed" Government has stolen.

Over 23,000 candidates opt for three new exam centres: UPSC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Union Public Service Commission (UPSC) on Thursday said over 23,000 civil services aspirants have opted for three newly introduced examination centres as part of efforts to decongest venues for examination.

With the addition of centres at Bhubaneswar, Kanpur, and Meerut, the total number of examination centres for the civil services (preliminary) examination has increased from 80 to 83, the Commission said.

"Nearly 23,000 candidates have applied to these new centres, easing the rush at the adjoining centres for the Civil Services (Preliminary) Examination-2026," the UPSC said in a statement.

The civil services exam is conducted annually in three stages — preliminary, mains, and interview — for recruitment to services including Indian Administrative Service (IAS), Indian Foreign Service (IFS), and Indian



Police Service (IPS). This year's civil services preliminary examination is scheduled to be held on Sunday. The Commission said it has received a total of 8,19,372 applications for the preliminary examination.

UPSC Chairman Ajay Kumar said the initiative aims to make the examination process more candidate-friendly, accessible, and efficient. "The addition of three new centres is aimed at easing congestion and providing greater convenience to aspirants," Kumar said.

He said that the Commission has also

ensured that Person with Benchmark Disabilities (PwBD) candidates are allotted their preferred examination centres, even beyond existing capacity, by creating additional seats where required. Aa a result, nearly 805 PwBD candidates got their centre of choice in the Delhi area alone, the Commission said.

The newly introduced Bhubaneswar centre received 10,656 applications and helped reduce the burden of the Cuttack centre, while Kanpur centre attracted 6,938 applications, easing pressure on Lucknow.

SMC 2026 guidelines not for private unaided schools: Education Ministry

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Education Ministry on Thursday clarified that the School Management Committee (SMC) Guidelines 2026 do not apply to private unaided schools that do not receive Government aid or grants. The clarification came amid concerns raised by certain sections of society regarding the implementation of the guidelines.

However, the ministry said such schools are still encouraged to constitute School Management Committees to promote greater transparency, accountability and participatory governance.

"With reference to concerns raised by certain sections of society regarding the School Management Committee Guidelines (SMCs) 2026, the Ministry of Education clarifies that the Guidelines are not applicable to private unaided schools covered under Section 2(n)(iv) of the RTE Act, provided such institu-



THE MINISTRY SAID SUCH SCHOOLS ARE STILL ENCOURAGED TO CONSTITUTE SCHOOL MANAGEMENT COMMITTEES TO PROMOTE GREATER TRANSPARENCY

tions do not receive any aid or grants from the appropriate Government or local authority towards meeting their expenses," the ministry said in a post on social media.

The ministry also stressed that education is a shared responsibility of the Government, schools, parents and the community. "Strengthening collabora-

tions among parents, schools and other stakeholders is essential to improving the overall functioning of schools and ensuring better learning outcomes for children," it added.

Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan on May 6 launched the guidelines, underscoring the need for stronger community participation,

improved school infrastructure and updated pedagogy in line with the National Education Policy 2020.

Pradhan had underlined that SMCs are not a new concept but have evolved over time and remain central to improving learning outcomes and governance in schools.

The guidelines introduced several key reforms, including a single SMC for all classes from 'Balvatika' to Class 12, aimed at strengthening school-level governance and continuity in decision-making.

The guidelines clearly define the roles and responsibilities of SMCs and member secretaries, with a focus on improved accountability, transparency and financial oversight in school management.

They also emphasise proactive monitoring of student attendance and teacher engagement to enhance learning outcomes.

From Assam to Ladakh: PM Modi showcases Indian crafts as diplomatic gifts

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A Muga silk stole for Italian Prime Minister Giorgia Meloni, a Madhubani painting with fish motif for Dutch Prime Minister Rob Jetten and a Ladakhi pure wool stole for Swedish Prime Minister Ulf Kristersson were some of the gifts presented by Prime Minister Narendra Modi during his just-concluded five-nation tour.

During his trip, Modi also gifted Kesar mangoes and Meghalaya pineapples to UAE President Sheikh Mohamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan, a replica of the ice axe used by Sherpa Tenzing Norgay to Iceland's Prime Minister Kristrún Frostadóttir and a Bidri silver work vase to Denmark's Prime Minister Mette Frederiksen among others, officials said. Modi visited the United Arab Emirates, the Netherlands, Sweden, Norway and Italy.

The Muga silk stole gifted to Meloni is a rare and prestigious textile from the Brahmaputra Valley. Muga silk is known as the "golden

silk" of Assam and is celebrated for its natural golden hue and understated elegance.

Italy's celebrated tradition of luxury textiles and timeless design finds a natural resonance in the elegance of Assam's "golden silk", the officials said.

The prime minister of Italy was also gifted a Shirui Lily silk stole, which draws its inspiration from the misty heights of Shirui Kashong peak in Manipur.

It is inspired by the rare Shirui Lily, a delicate bell-shaped flower with pale pinkish-white petals that blooms nowhere else in the world.

For the Tangkhul Naga community of Manipur, the Shirui Lily symbolises purity, identity and cultural pride. The lily also holds deep cultural resonance in Italy, where it has long symbolised purity, grace and artistic refinement, frequently appearing in Renaissance art.

President of Italy Sergio Mattarella was gifted a marble inlay work box with CDs of legendary Hindustani classical vocalist Pandit

Bhimsen Joshi and Carnatic singer MS Subbulakshmi. The box is a refined example of India's handcrafted artistry, closely associated with the master craftsmen of Agra.

Created using the intricate art of Pacchikari, or Pietra Dura, this decorative tradition is believed to have originated in Florence, Italy, before flourishing in India under royal patronage, making it a remarkable artistic bridge between the two nations.

Together, the marble inlay box and the timeless musical works celebrate the shared appreciation of India and Italy for art, heritage and cultural excellence.

King Willem-Alexander of the Netherlands was gifted blue pottery from Jaipur. It is a GI-tagged art form with deep Indian roots, iconic for its vibrant cobalt blue, white, and yellow designs.

It stands as a celebrated symbol of Indian craftsmanship, blending traditional artistry with contemporary design. With the Netherlands' world-famous heritage of producing masterful Delft Blue pottery, these pieces



are an ode to a shared commitment to artistic excellence, the officials said.

Queen of the Netherlands Maxima was gifted Meenakari and Kundan earrings. These earrings embody the finest traditions of Indian jewellery craftsmanship, originating from the royal ateliers of Rajasthan.

Prime Minister of the Netherlands Rob Jetten was gifted a Madhubani painting with a fish motif. Madhubani painting is a GI-tagged folk art tradition from the Mithila

region known for its intricate geometric patterns and vibrant colours.

Prime Minister of Norway Jonas Gahr Støre was gifted a pressed orchid painting and orchid paperweights. These exquisite artworks, composed of real pressed orchids and ferns from the mist-covered valleys of Sikkim, celebrate the extraordinary biodiversity of the Eastern Himalayas.

King Harald V of Norway was gifted an intricate sailboat model. This exquisite

silver sailboat is a masterpiece of Tarakasi, the ancient art of silver filigree from Cuttack, Odisha, the officials said.

Queen Sonja of Norway was gifted a palm leaf Pattachitra, locally known as Tala Pattachitra, one of Odisha's most ancient and intricate art forms.

Apart from the Ladakh pure wool stole, the Swedish PM was also gifted the Loktak tea, an artisanal, small-batch tea from the lush hills surrounding the largest freshwater lake in the northeast, and a handcrafted Santiniketan messenger bag.

Iceland's prime minister was gifted a replica of the ice axe used by Norgay as a tribute to the legendary tool carried by the Sherpa guide of Sir Edmund Hillary on the first ascent of Mount Everest in 1953.

The prime minister of Denmark was gifted a Bidri silver work vase, which reflects the refined artistry of the Deccan, celebrated for its intricate silver inlay, elegant form, and meticulous craftsmanship. Finland's Prime

Minister Petteri Orpo was given a Kamal Talai Pichwai painting, which reflects the serene beauty and devotional artistry of the Nathdwara tradition of Rajasthan.

The UAE president was gifted a Rogan painting with the tree of life. The Rogan painting is a rare and exquisite textile art form from the Kutch region of Gujarat.

He was also given Kesar mangoes, a GI-tagged fruit also known as Gujarat's "Queen of Mangoes", and Meghalaya's pineapples, which are celebrated as some of the finest in the world, thriving in the hilly terrain of Meghalaya.

The UAE crown prince was gifted a dagger with Koftgari work. A ceremonial dagger, adorned with intricate Koftgari work, is a rare expression of India's martial and artistic heritage, and Mithila makhana, a premium agricultural product from the Mithila region of Bihar.

The UAE Queen Mother was gifted Maheshwari silk fabric, one of India's most elegant handloom traditions, originating in the historic

town of Maheshwar on the banks of the Narmada river in Madhya Pradesh, and Chak Hao rice, famously known as Manipur's "black rice", a prized aromatic rice variety from the fertile valleys of the northeast.

Qu Dongyu, Director-General of the Food and Agriculture Organisation of the UN, was gifted red rice, an indigenous grain from the black soils of Palakkad, Kerala; Gobindobhog rice, a premium, aromatic short-grain rice from West Bengal; Basmati rice a premium long-grain variety originating from the Indo-Gangetic plains; Joha rice, a premium, indigenous aromatic variety exclusive to the fertile Brahmaputra Valley of Assam; and Kalanamak rice, often called the "Buddha Rice", which originated in the Terai region of Uttar Pradesh.

He was also given healthy millet bars. Millets are an integral part of Maharashtra's agricultural heritage, widely cultivated in regions such as Solapur, Ahmednagar, and the Marathwada belt.

States Focus



BANKS MUST ENSURE CREDIT REACHES FARMERS: FADNAVIS

Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis on Thursday directed banks, especially the nationalised lenders, to handle agricultural loan disbursal with greater seriousness and ensure that credit reaches farmers, MSMEs and the rural economy. Speaking at the 171st meeting of the State Level Bankers' Committee (SLBC) at the Sahyadri Guest House here, Fadnavis said banks should not function solely with a profit motive and must adopt a broader approach towards strengthening agriculture and rural development. "Credit is increasing, but the number of accounts is declining," Fadnavis said.



BIHAR CM REVIEWS FLOOD, DROUGHT PREPAREDNESS

Bihar Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary on Thursday directed officials to remain alert in view of the possibility of both floods and drought-like conditions in the State. Chairing a review meeting at the Chief Minister's Secretariat, Choudhary asked officials to ensure timely preparedness and swift response to any disaster situation. "Do not allow a disaster to turn into a calamity. Extend full support to people during any disaster situation. The Government stands with the people. The first right over the state treasury belongs to disaster victims," he said, according to a statement issued by the Chief Minister's Office (CMO).

States Focus



NOD TO AYODHYA NAGAR BYPASS PROJECT IN MP

Paving the way for the Ayodhya Nagar Bypass Project in Madhya Pradesh's Bhopal, the National Green Tribunal (NGT) has said there is no illegality in felling 7,871 trees for the proposed work as it has been duly approved by a centrally-empowered committee. The green body was hearing a petition challenging the National Highways Authority of India's (NHAI) proposal to fell the trees for the proposed Asharam Tiraha-to-Ratnagiri Tiraha Ayodhya Bypass Project in Bhopal. The plea had sought the cancellation of the project by considering an alternative route to avoid unnecessary felling of trees. The 16.5-km road-development project entails the six-laning of both sides of the service road of the Ayodhya Bypass near the Ashram Tiraha on NH-46 till the Ratnagiri Tiraha on NH-146.



GOVT TO LAUNCH CAMPAIGN AGAINST STRAY DOGS: MANN

Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann on Thursday said his Government will launch a campaign starting Friday against stray and killer dogs which endanger the lives of people. On May 19, the Supreme Court in a significant verdict allowed euthanasia of rabid, incurably ill, dangerous and aggressive dogs to curb threat to human lives, saying the right to live with dignity encompasses the right to move freely without the threat of harm from canines.

\$40 bn investment push after PM's 5-nation trip

RAJESH KUMAR
■ New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi's recent five-nation visit has helped India secure an investment pipeline worth nearly \$40 billion, with several multinational firms committing fresh investments and expansion plans across key sectors.

PM Modi held meetings with chief executives and senior representatives of over 50 global companies during the tour, covering sectors such as semiconductors, logistics, infrastructure, defence, energy and technology. The combined market valuation of these companies is estimated between \$2.7 trillion and \$3 trillion.



Addressing a press conference, Union minister Piyush Goyal on Thursday said Prime Minister Narendra Modi's five-nation tour has yielded "concrete outcomes" for the benefit of everyone in the country and slammed Congress leader Rahul Gandhi for calling the prime

minister a "traitor". Goyal listed the outcomes of the prime minister's just-concluded visit to the UAE, Norway, Sweden, the Netherlands and Italy, and said Modi has returned with "something or the other" for every section in India. During his five-day foreign tour, the

prime minister was also conferred three international awards, he added. "On the one hand, the entire world looks upon Prime Minister Modi with immense confidence, on the other, Rahul Gandhi, who has a negative mindset, repeatedly reveals his true nature and character through his words and language," he added.

Goyal said Rahul Gandhi stooping to hurling abuses at the prime minister in an "extremely petty language" is "truly deplorable". "Tell me, is the ending of Naxalism an act of *gaddari* (betrayal)" or was allowing Naxalism to fester for years under the Congress rule the true act of 'gaddari'? Would we label the act of enhancing the

global prestige of the tricolour as 'gaddari'? "Or, would we consider it 'gaddari' when one travels abroad only to disparage India's tricolour?" the senior BJP leader asked.

India and the UAE signed seven agreements during PM Modi's stopover, including a strategic defence partnership framework, energy cooperation deals and a proposed maritime infrastructure project at Vadinar in Gujarat. The UAE also committed investments worth \$5 billion across Indian infrastructure and financial sectors. India and the Netherlands elevated bilateral ties to a strategic partnership and unveiled a roadmap covering trade, semiconduc-

tors, artificial intelligence, quantum computing, green hydrogen and maritime security.

The visit also produced 17 agreements, including cooperation in critical minerals, renewable energy and defence manufacturing. India and Sweden upgraded relations to a strategic partnership, with both countries endorsing a joint action plan for 2026-2030 focused on green transition, emerging technologies, trade, defence and climate action.

Goyal said Modi has kept the country secure which reflects his "true patriotism". "The way the Congress party and the Gandhi family provide patronage to infiltrators, that is 'gaddari'," he added.

Omar faces internal dissent over demolition drive

MOHIT KANDHARI ■ Jammu

Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah is once again facing opposition from within the party ranks over the manner in which a demolition drive was carried out by officials of the Forest Department, headed by the National Conference Cabinet Minister Javed Ahmed Rana in Jammu.

Approximately 3 hectares (60 kanals) of encroached forest land were reclaimed during the drive, where 32 illegal structures were demolished early Tuesday morning. On Thursday, a National Conference Member of Parliament, Syed Aga Ruhullah Mehdi, fired a fresh salvo targeting Omar Abdullah. After paying condolences at the residence of Engineer Rashid in Handwara, Ruhullah reacted strongly over the manner in which the demolition drive was conducted to evict the encroachers in Jammu.

"Demolishing homes of Gujjar-Bakarwal families in Sidhra, many on electoral rolls since 1952, without notice or due process, is indefensible. The land is reportedly revenue, not forest. Affected families must be reha-



bilitated, and those responsible held accountable". He said the Government has consistently disappointed the people of Jammu and Kashmir.

Feeling the heat over the matter, Deputy Chief Minister Surinder Kumar Choudhary, in the absence of the Chief Minister, who is yet to make any statement, said the elected Government in Jammu and Kashmir is functioning with limited powers and alleged that major decisions are being taken by the bureaucracy instead of the representatives chosen by the people.

Choudhary said the recent demolition drive in Jammu would not have

happened if Jammu and Kashmir had retained full statehood. Questioning the demolition of houses, he said the structures had existed for years and were not built overnight.

"If these constructions were illegal, where were the concerned departments all these years?" he asked, calling the demolitions unfortunate.

People's Democratic Party leader, Iltija Mufti, also visited the members of the affected families in Jammu on Thursday. After meeting several affected members, Iltija told reporters, "A common thing which all families told me is that BJP MLA Vikram Randhawa came here about 10 days ago and said that all of this is illegal and they will demolish this. There is no coincidence that the BJP gives direction to the NC that a drive has to be carried out here. Who does the Forest Department come under? This started in April in RS Pura, then in Kathua and now here.

So, this is like systematic planning. BJP gives them directions, and NC implements it...NC should take responsibility for this. They cannot claim 'UT, UT' for everything..."

Race for next IB chief heats up, hunt on for successor

RAJESH KUMAR/PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH ■ New Delhi

With IB Director Tapan Kumar Deka's second extension ending June 30, 2026, the contest to head India's internal intelligence agency has entered its final phase. Senior IPS officers with intelligence experience are under consideration, though no formal shortlist has been released.

One name emerging strongly from multiple corridors of power is Sunil Acharya, a 1991-batch Nagaland-cadre IPS officer currently serving as Special Secretary in the Research and Analysis Wing (R&AW). Acharya is noted for his rare cross-agency expertise and a reputation for operational effectiveness.

During his years in the IB, Acharya played a key role as staff officer to former Director Rajiv Jain, a period marked by the agency's success in



solving several high-profile terror and espionage cases. His experience solidified his proficiency in developing human intelligence networks and conducting sensitive operations. Acharya's tradecraft, reflecting Jain philosophy's prioritisation of human intelligence over excessive reliance on technology, is considered one of his core strengths.

In 2019, he moved to R&AW, where his steady rise has included overseas postings and gained him

broad institutional insight. Acharya's effectiveness stems from an understated operational style, a comprehensive intelligence background, and a proven track record in handling both internal and external intelligence matters.

His ability to adapt, foster inter-agency coherence, and manage sensitive security operations positions him as a strong candidate for the IB Director role, especially given India present challenges in counter-terrorism, radicalisation, hybrid threats, and border stability.

Deka, who received extensions citing persistent security challenges, has focused his tenure on strengthening human intelligence networks, improving inter-agency coordination, and proactively addressing evolving threats.

There is another contender, Rithwik Rudra, IPS, 1993 batch, Himachal Cadre, who is seen as the

incumbent Deka's preferred choice. He has extensive hands-on IB experience, having served at the Additional Director and Joint Director levels and a family legacy in the IPS; his father, Kalyan Rudra, was Haryana DGP.

The next IB Director will inherit an expanded mandate that spans counter-terror operations, cyber intelligence, monitoring of internal stability, and coordination in an increasingly politically charged environment. The Appointments Committee of the Cabinet (ACC) is expected to take a final call in the coming weeks.

While no official announcement has been made, the decision will be among the most closely watched appointments in India's security establishment this year. The appointment will reveal the Government's internal security priorities as discussions continue ahead of the June 30 deadline.



Devotees gather near the Madmaheshwar temple after the doors of the second Kedarnath temple were opened for devotees amid chanting of Vedic mantras in Rudraprayag district, Uttarakhand on Thursday

1,000 pilgrims selected for Kailash Manasarovar Yatra



ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar conducted the computerised draw for the selection of pilgrims for the Kailash Manasarovar Yatra 2026 on Wednesday.

The Ministry of External Affairs announced that the 2026 edition of the pilgrimage will commence in June and conclude in August.

A total of 1,000 Yatris have been selected through a fair, computer-generated, random, and gender-balanced process.

According to the ministry, the selected pilgrims will travel in 20 batches, with each batch comprising 50 Yatris. The pilgrimage will be conducted through the Lipulekh Pass and Nathu La Pass routes, both of which are now fully motorable, significantly reducing the need for trekking.

The Yatra was resumed last year after a gap of nearly

five years as part of efforts to normalise the relation between India and China.

It was suspended initially in 2020 because of the Covid-19 pandemic and subsequently because of the military standoff between the two sides on the Line Of Actual (LAC) in easter Ladakh.

Officials stated that detailed information regarding routes and batch allocations is available on the official Yatra portal.

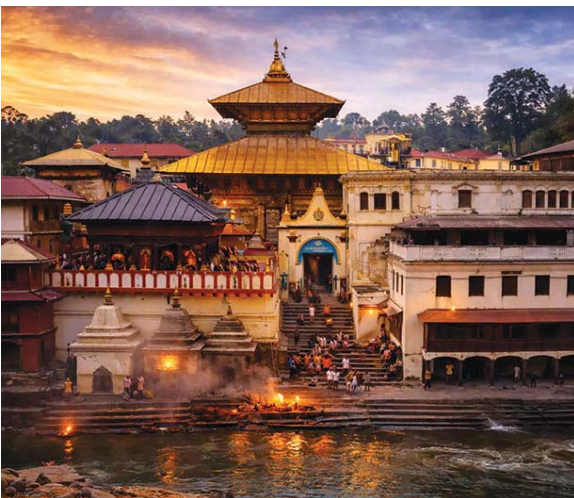
Notifications regarding selection have been sent to shortlisted applicants via SMS and email. Applicants can also check their selection status by visiting Kailash Manasarovar Yatra Portal.

The Kailash Manasarovar Yatra is considered one of the most significant spiritual pilgrimages for Hindus, Buddhists, Jains, and followers of Bon tradition, attracting devotees from across India every year.

Amit Shah gifts rare sandalwood at Pashupatinath Temple

SHIRISH B PRADHAN
■ Kathmandu

The sandalwood gifted by India was handed over to Ganesh Bhatta, the main priest of the Pashupatinath temple, in coordination with Sandeep Rana, a member of Nepal's House of Representatives. Union Home Minister Amit Shah sent over 40 kilograms of sandalwood for the purpose of using it for the worship of the Shree Yantra of Pashupatinath Temple, according to officials at the Pashupati Area Development Trust that manages the



affairs of the temple.

The sandalwood received by main priest Bhatta was handed over to Chief of the Guthi Sansthan Pashupati Goswara Office, Sushila Sharma, for storage on Thursday itself, the officials said. Nepal receives such a special type of sandalwood from India every year in line with close religious and cultural ties between the two countries. People from both Nepal and India visit the Pashupatinath temple, one of the most sacred Hindu temples situated on the banks of the Bagmati river. (PTI)

Send Bangladeshi infiltrators to BSF, not courts: Suwendu

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

West Bengal Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari on Thursday said Bangladeshi infiltrators detained in the state would be handed over to the BSF, instead of being produced before courts, in line with a new rule that came into effect a day ago.

Speaking to reporters after an administrative review meeting at the Howrah district magistrate's office, Adhikari said instructions had already been issued to the police commissioner and the Railway Protection Force (RPF) in this regard. "Since yesterday, the new rule has come into effect

under which infiltrators will not be sent to courts but handed over to the BSF at the Bangladesh border," he said.

Adhikari on Wednesday announced the implementation of a mechanism under which infiltrators detained by state police would be handed over directly to the BSF for deportation, unveiling what he described as part of a broader "detect, delete and deport" framework.

The chief minister did not name the Act under whose purview the newly elected BJP Government in Bengal made the policy shift for prosecution of infiltrators.

However, it seemed Adhikari was referring to the Immigration and Foreigners



Act, 2025, passed by Parliament in April last year, which aims to provide a modern, tech-driven system for immigration, registration, surveillance, detention, and deportation in India.

"The police commissioner

and the RPF have been clearly instructed that if any migrant from Bangladesh, who is not entitled to apply for citizenship under the CAA, is detained at Howrah station, he or she should not be sent to a court. The person con-

Injectable cosmetics not permitted for use: CDSCO

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Cosmetic products supplied in injectable form do not fall under the definition of cosmetics under the law and are not permitted for use by consumers, professionals or aesthetic clinics, the central drug regulator has made it clear.

The advisory by the Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation's (CDSCO) comes amid the growing popularity of injectable aesthetic procedures being promoted as "cos-

metic" treatments in beauty clinics and wellness centres across the country. The clarification is aimed at preventing misuse of cosmetic products for treatment purposes and ensuring consumer safety, particularly as non-surgical aesthetic procedures gain popularity in urban centres and through social media promotion, a source said.

The move also seeks to curb misleading advertising and unauthorised cosmetic practices by clinics and individuals.

ment-related issues concerning Howrah city on the other bank of the Hooghly river.

Adhikari said a coordination committee had been constituted under the district magistrate to ensure clean drinking water supplies, proper drainage systems and other civic amenities in the Howrah Municipal Corporation area.

The committee would be monitored by Municipal Affairs Secretary Khalil Ahmed, he added.

Adhikari also said the state Government and the railways would jointly identify and list their respective responsibilities for improving civic infrastructure in the city.

Congress pay tribute to Rajiv Gandhi on death anniversary

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Congress leader Sonia Gandhi, Congress President Mallikarjun Kharge and Rahul Gandhi, besides several other Congress leaders on Thursday paid tributes to former prime minister Rajiv Gandhi on his death anniversary. He was born on August 20, 1944, in Mumbai and was assassinated in Sriperumbudur in Tamil Nadu on May 21, 1991.

“Tributes to former Prime Minister Shri Rajiv Gandhi ji on his death anniversary,” Modi said in a post on social media. Rajiv Gandhi served as India’s prime minister from October 31, 1984, to December 2, 1989.

Sonia Gandhi, Rahul Gandhi and Mallikarjun Kharge paid tributes to the former prime minister Rajiv Gandhi on his 35th death anniversary, and recalled the various initiatives undertaken by him for the country’s progress.

Besides members of the Gandhi family, many former chief ministers and union ministers paid their tributes to Rajiv Gandhi at his memorial Veer Bhumi here.

Paying tribute, former Congress president Rahul Gandhi said his father’s teachings and values will always remain with him.



Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi and Congress leader Sonia Gandhi paying tribute to former prime minister Rajiv Gandhi on his death anniversary at Veer Bhumi in New Delhi on Thursday

PTI

“Papa, I will fully shoulder the responsibility of realising the dream of a skilled, prosperous, and strong India that you envisioned,” Rahul Gandhi said in a post on social media. “Your teachings, your values, and your memories will always remain with me,” he said.

After paying floral tributes to the former prime minister, Congress chief Kharge recalled Rajiv Gandhi’s words: “India is an old country but a young nation. I dream of India — strong, independent, self-reliant and in the front rank of the nations of the world, in the service of mankind”. In a post on social media, Kharge said, “On his martyrdom day, we

pay our deepest respects to Former Prime Minister and Bharat Ratna Rajiv Gandhi, a remarkable son of India who inspired hope and aspiration in millions across the nation.”

With vision, courage, and a deep belief in India’s future, he laid the foundations for the country’s journey into the twenty first century, Kharge recalled.

“His transformative initiatives included lowering the voting age to eighteen, empowering local self governance through Panchayati Raj, ushering in the telecom and information technology revolution, advancing computerisation, securing important peace accords, launching

the Universal Immunisation Programme, and introducing a forward looking education policy centred on inclusive learning. “His legacy continues to shape modern India and remains a source of inspiration for generations,” the Congress chief said in a post on social media.

Congress general secretary Priyanka Gandhi Vadra and K C Venugopal, former chief ministers Bhupinder Singh Hooda and Ashok Gehlot, besides several former union ministers were present at his memorial Veer Bhumi.

Several Congress leaders also remembered Rajiv Gandhi as the architect of modern India.

Gurugram homebuyers fraud: ED seeks witness protection from police in 3 States

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

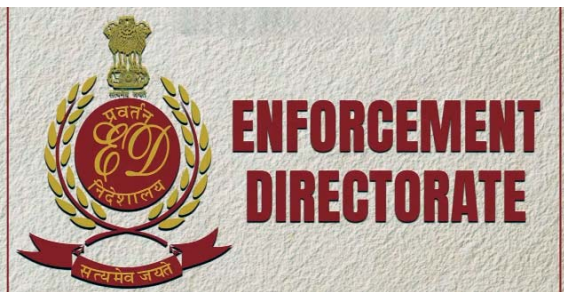
The Enforcement Directorate has written to the police forces of three States asking them to ensure protection for homebuyers and witnesses who alleged receiving threats on behalf of Swaraj Singh Yadav, the arrested promoter of Gurugram-based realty firm Ocean Seven Buildtech Pvt Ltd.

In November 2025, the central agency arrested Yadav in a money laundering case linked to the alleged duping of buyers of affordable housing projects through arbitrary cancellations and re-allotments.

During the hearing of a plea filed by Yadav seeking regular bail on May 18, some victims informed the designated court in Delhi about the “threats”, “intimidation” and “coercive tactics” being used against them for depositing before the ED as part of this investigation.

The victims informed Additional Sessions Judge (Patiala House Courts) Shefali Barnala Tandon that a man began recording their video while they waited outside the court on the said date.

Some other victims, including an Army officer and a senior citizen, told the court that they were being



threatened “at the instance” of Yadav. The court was also informed that “false” FIRs were being filed against some of them in Rajasthan as they claimed Yadav and his associates were operating as a “mafia”.

ED’s investigating officer told the court that “he has received 10 complaints from the victims/homebuyers of the present matter of threatening at the instance of accused Swaraj Singh.”

“It has also been stated by the IO that even the prosecution witnesses are receiving calls on behalf of accused Swaraj Singh for resiling from their statements given to the ED and depositing in their favour,” the court said in its order of May 18.

Observing that multiple victims have “consistently projected a palpable and bonafide apprehension to their life and liberty”, the court ordered the deputy commissioner of police (DCP) of New Delhi to ensure

“protective” arrangements for the victims until the ED undertakes appropriate witness protection measures.

According to officials, the ED followed the court’s directions and wrote to the DCP of Delhi Police, providing the names of the victims and prosecution witnesses so that the police can extend protection to them.

The agency also wrote to the Gurugram (Haryana) police commissioner and its EOW (the predicate agency in the case against Yadav and his company), informing them about the said court order and the threats the victims reported receiving.

The ED also wrote to the inspector general of police (Jaipur range) in Rajasthan, informing the authority about the “false” FIRs being filed under its jurisdiction against the victims by certain persons allegedly linked to Yadav, the officials said.

New helipad inaugurated to cater growing rush at Vaishno Devi: LG Sinha

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

To cater to the growing rush of pilgrims opting for helicopter services to visit the Cave Shrine of Mata Vaishno Devi, a newly constructed helipad was inaugurated by the Jammu and Kashmir Lieutenant Governor (LG) Manoj Sinha on Thursday in Katra.

The facility will be used to streamline helicopter services for pilgrims visiting the Mata Vaishno Devi and Shiv Khori shrines. Built at a cost of around ₹27 crore, the helipad is expected to improve connectivity and provide major relief to devotees travelling to the twin shrines, officials said, adding that helicopter services from Katra to Shiv Khori will commence soon.

Addressing reporters after inaugurating the helipad at Katra, Sinha said the Mata Vaishno Devi Board and the Shiv Khori Board — both civil authorities — have jointly developed the facility.

“It is a very modern heliport, designed keeping in view passenger facilities and with full emphasis on safety,” he said. The LG said the heliport has been constructed in accordance with the Directorate General of Civil Aviation’s (DGCA) norms.

75,000 CAPF to remain in West Bengal till June 20 for post-election duties



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

The Union Home Ministry has decided to continue deploying 500 companies of Central Armed Police Forces (CAPFs) in West Bengal till June 20 for post-poll law and order management based on a request from the West Bengal Government, an official said Thursday.

In an official communication, the home ministry said the West Bengal Government had sought continuation of the Central forces’ deployment till the end of October for post-election duties.

“The request of the Government of West Bengal has been considered in this ministry,” it said. The communication addressed to the West Bengal chief secretary, home secretary and director general of police stated that 500 companies of CAPFs, comprising 200 of the CRPF, 150 of the BSF, and 50 each of the CISF, ITBP and SSB, would continue to remain deployed in the state till June 20.

A senior state Government official said the forces are being retained primarily to assist police in maintaining law and order in sensitive areas following the Assembly election.

“The deployment is aimed at ensuring peace and preventing any untoward incidents in vulnerable areas. Coordination between the state police and CAPFs is continuing,” the official said.

The Union Home Ministry has also asked the West Bengal Government to ensure necessary logistics, accommodation and other operational arrangements for the central forces stationed across the state.

On May 16, Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari, during an administrative review meeting held at Diamond Harbour, requested the chief secretary and home secretary to seek an extension of the stay of CAPF personnel beyond the scheduled two-month period.

Incidentally, Union Home Minister Amit Shah, during one of his rallies for the just-concluded assembly polls in Bengal, had said that a total of 500 companies of CAPF would extend their stay in the state for 60 days after the election, primarily to keep a check on the post-poll violence.

The two-phase polling in Bengal got over on April 29, and the counting was held on May 4.

Ranjeet Kumar Dass elected as Speaker of Assam Assembly

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

Four-time BJP MLA Ranjeet Kumar Dass was on Thursday unanimously elected as the Speaker of the 16th Assam Legislative Assembly, becoming the only legislator in the state to assume the chair for the second time.

Pro tem Speaker Chandra Mohan Patowary announced that there were three nominations in favour of Dass, and no one contested him.

“As there is no other nomination, I declare Ranjeet Kumar Dass as the Speaker of the 16th Assam Legislative Assembly,” he added.

This is the second term for Dass as the Speaker of the Assembly. He was in the chair in 2016 when the BJP formed its first Government in the northeastern state.

Dass, the MLA from Bhowanipur-Sorbhog seat, was a cabinet minister during Himanta Biswa Sarma’s first term as CM from 2021 to 2026. He also served the party as



Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Thursday extended his greetings and felicitations to the newly elected Speaker of the Assam Legislative Assembly, Ranjeet Kumar Dass

PIONEER PHOTO

its Assam unit chief. Dass has been elected to the Assam Assembly for four consecutive terms since 2011.

After his election, Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma congratulated Dass.

“Today, you have made history. You are the only person who is assuming the

Speaker’s chair for the second time,” Sarma said.

Legislators from the ruling coalition and the opposition parties also congratulated Dass and offered their full support for his tenure.

“We expect you to be fully neutral in the House. We, the opposition, have very few

seats this time. So, we will be allotted less time. However, we expect you to show some leniency and give more time to present the issues affecting the people,” Congress MLA Jakir Hussain Sikdar said.

Dass, while acknowledging the support of the MLAs, said he would be neutral inside the House. “However, I am a member of a political party following a particular ideology. It is not easy to leave it instantly,” he added.

Dass also objected to the word ‘Speaker’, saying it originated from British rule.

“I hope there will be some discussions in this House on the usage of the word — Speaker. Sabhapati or Adhyaksh words sound fine. In future, I will try to work as per Indian culture and tradition. I will not follow the British tradition,” he added.

The Speaker also appealed to all members to make the Assam Legislative Assembly a model House in the country.



Tourists at the snow-covered Baralacha Pass on the Manali-Leh Highway in Lahaul and Spiti district, Himachal Pradesh on Thursday

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BRO successfully launches 170 feet Bailey bridge in Bihar

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bihar

Vikramshila Setu, a vital 4.88 km-long bridge over the River Ganga connecting NH-33 (Old NH-80) and NH-31, serves as a lifeline for Bhagalpur and adjoining regions. Following the collapse of the 34-meter navigational span of the bridge, traffic movement was completely disrupted, severely affecting public mobility and the movement of essential services.

Realising the urgency of the situation, the Government of Bihar requested immediate assistance from the Ministry of Defence for the deployment of emer-

gency bridging solutions to facilitate the movement of light vehicles and essential services. The Ministry of Defence entrusted the restoration works to Border Roads Organisation (BRO).

Consequently, BRO has undertaken the challenging task of launching these Bailey Bridges to restore connectivity and provide immediate relief to the affected population of North & South Bihar on a war footing. The Construction Team of Project Swastik has launched 170 Feet Bailey bridge in a short time. In addition to the two Bailey bridges that have been launched so far, as requisitioned by the State Government, two more



Bailey bridges will also be launched over distressed spans of the Vikramshila Setu shortly.

Shri Jitendra Prasad, VSM, Additional Director General Border Roads (East), visited the bridge site on 20 May

2026. During his inspection visit, Jitendra Prasad, VSM, expressed his satisfaction with the fast pace of construction of the 170-feet Bailey bridge and assured the State administration of expeditious construction of

the remaining two bridges.

Before visiting the bridge site, the ADG also had an interaction with Pankaj Kumar Pal, Secretary, RCD at Patna. Jitendra Kumar, MD, BRPNL and Bipin Kumar Chand, Superintending Engineer, BRO, attended the meeting.

The State Administration has also expressed profound gratitude to the Border Roads Organisation for its timely intervention and fast-paced construction efforts.

Restoration of connectivity is expected to greatly ease transportation hardships, ensure continuity of essential services and provide much-needed succor to the local populace.

Minister dedicates UMMID programme to nation

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Union minister Jitendra Singh on Thursday said the UMMID programme for rare genetic disorders and diseases has already benefited nearly three lakh individuals through screening and diagnostic services.

Launched in 2019, the Unique Methods of Management of Inherited Disorders (UMMID) initiative is supported by the Department of Biotechnology.

The programme has also helped establish nearly 30 National Inherited Diseases Administration (NIDAN) kendras for advanced diagnostics and counselling, ensuring that advanced genomic healthcare reaches beyond metropolitan centres.

Singh, the Minister of State (Independent Charge)



of the Ministry of Science and Technology, said, “The UMMID programme has successfully established a national framework integrating genetic diagnostics, prenatal and newborn screening, genetic counselling, clinician capacity-building and community outreach under a unified public health model.”

The minister made these comments during an event for the dedication of the UMMID initiative to the nation.

Congress joins TVK Govt, Vijay expands Cabinet by inducting 23 more ministers

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay on Thursday expanded his Cabinet by inducting 23 more legislators as ministers, including two from the Congress, which marked the return of the grand old party to governance in Tamil Nadu after almost 60 years.

The swearing-in ceremony was held at the Lok Bhavan and Governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar administered the oath of office and secrecy to the minister-designates. TVK MLAs, including Srinath, S Kamali, C Vijayalakshmi and RV Ranjithkumar were initially sworn-in as ministers.

Congress party’s S Rajesh Kumar, representing Killiyoor, and P Viswanathan, who won from Melur segment, took oath as ministers.

AICC incharge for Tamil Nadu, Girish Chodankar, said the inclusion of his party MLAs in the Cabinet heralded a “turning point” in the political history of Tamil Nadu.

“Congress cadres have been striving for power for the last 59 years and have been working for it with loyalty and dedication. Now, they have got it,” Chodankar told PTI Videos. Congress Lok Sabha (Karur) MP Jothimani said in a statement: “After 59 years, two members of the Congress party have taken up positions in the Tamil Nadu Cabinet. This is a highly joyful moment for the Congress party. Heartfelt congratula-



Tamil Nadu Governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar and CM C Joseph Vijay felicitate TVK MLA N Marie Wilson, who took oath of office as Minister for Finance, Planning and Development at the Lok Bhavan in Chennai

PTI

tions to elder brother Viswanathan and younger brother Rajeshkumar! May this responsibility turn out to be a great opportunity to render exemplary service to the people of Tamil Nadu.”

Also, Congress supporters hailed in social media the inclusion of party MLAs in the Cabinet on May 21, the death anniversary of iconic leader Rajiv Gandhi.

A total of 23 MLAs were sworn in as ministers and it includes three women. Vijay’s friend Srinath, elected from Thoothukudi Assembly segment, was the first to take oath. Mohamed Farvas J, and N Marie Wilson were from the minority communities.

Governor Arlekar corrected Congress leader Rajesh Kumar during his oath-taking and asked him to confine to the written oath given to him. While reading out the oath from a paper, he sudden-

ly hailed Congress leaders Kamaraj, Rajiv Gandhi and Rahul Gandhi, spontaneously prompting the Governor to say, “that is not part of your oath.” The Cabinet expansion marks the Congress’ return to Government in Tamil Nadu after nearly six decades as the Dravidian majors—DMK and AIADMK, have never accommodated allies, including the national party that has aligned with both parties at different points of time. The last Congress chief minister was M Bhakthavatsalam and he helmed Tamil Nadu, then known as Madras state, from 1963 to 1967.

The first non-Congress Government in post-independent India was ushered in by Dravidian stalwart and DMK founder CN Annadurai in 1967 when he led the party to a stupendous win against the then ruling Congress.



Editor's
TAKE

India expands its European footprint

By strengthening ties with Italy, India is securing economic opportunities, strategic connectivity and diplomatic leverage to shape its global standing

Prime Minister Narendra Modi's five-nation tour finally took him to Italy, which marks far more than another diplomatic engagement. The visit is a concerted effort to deepen economic, technological, and geopolitical partnerships with Western Europe, of which Italy is a key constituent. PM Modi's talks with Italian Prime Minister Giorgia Meloni would immensely benefit India in terms of trade, connectivity, defence cooperation, and India's strategic positioning.

The decision to elevate India-Italy relations into a "special strategic partnership" is not only a big step towards cementing relations but also an effort to move beyond the realm of given groupings and alliances. Both countries are seeking long-term cooperation in critical sectors such as defence manufacturing, clean energy, critical minerals, technology, maritime security and infrastructure. One of the major strategic discussions during the visit revolved around the India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor (IMEC), the Indian answer to the Chinese Belt and Road initiative. This project aims to link India with Europe through ports, rail networks and digital infrastructure across the Middle East. Italy's support is especially valuable because of its geographic location as a gateway to Europe and the Mediterranean region. Economically, the visit opens fresh opportunities for Indian businesses and exporters. Bilateral trade between India and Italy has already crossed ₹14 billion, and both countries are aiming for ₹20 billion by 2029. Modi's tour also involves business leaders from both sides. The talks on investment flows in manufacturing, green technologies, automobiles, defence production and innovation sectors could be a game-changer for India and Indian companies get an edge by collaborating with their Italian counterparts to upgrade technology and get access to a larger European market. This could generate employment and support India's ambition of becoming a global manufacturing hub. Europe is increasingly looking toward India as a reliable democratic partner amid geopolitical tensions, disruptions in supply chains and concerns over excessive dependence on China. For India, closer ties with Italy can help broaden its influence within the European Union and accelerate cooperation in areas such as artificial intelligence, climate action and food security. But this visit was not just about strategic and economic outreach, as it had cultural undertones to it. Modi's references to the civilisational connection between Rome and Varanasi highlighted the cultural depth shared by both nations. Such symbolism builds emotional and historical bridges alongside strategic interests.

Critics may dismiss the optics and personal chemistry between Modi and Meloni as political theatre. However, modern diplomacy is all about personal rapport to ease difficult negotiations and fast-track partnerships. Behind the headlines and social media moments lies a serious strategic recalibration— it is India's transition from a regional power to an increasingly influential global actor.

Flex-fuel: The future of India's ethanol push

At a time when even the EV transition remains heavily dependent on imported components, flex-fuel may well represent India's most realistic route towards true energy self-reliance.



KUSHAN MITRA

India has already proved it can move quickly on ethanol. The question now is whether it can move smartly.

The answer is not to linger over halfway stops like E22, E25 or E27. The next logical step is flex-fuel. If India wants lower oil dependence, a stronger domestic fuel base and a transport system that can actually scale, flex-fuel is the cleaner and more durable path.

The logic is simple. Flex-fuel vehicles allow consumers to use whatever blend is available locally, whether E20, E85 or E100. That flexibility matters in a country as large and uneven as India, where fuel availability, logistics and regional supply conditions vary widely. It also saves automakers from repeatedly spending on separate development and testing programmes for every new blend level. One vehicle platform, many fuel options: that is the real efficiency gain.

This debate matters even more now because the global oil environment has become increasingly unstable. The West Asia crisis is another reminder that India's transport fuel system is still too exposed to imported crude and the geopolitical shocks that come with it. The Prime Minister's call to conserve fuel and reduce import dependence is therefore not just political messaging. It is a strategic warning.

On that measure, ethanol-blended flex-fuel vehicles make a strong case for themselves. They are, in effect, Atmanirbhar. The fuel can be produced domestically. The feedstock can be sourced domestically. The value chain stays largely within India. In a period when energy security is being tested from every direction, that is not a small advantage.

The case for flex-fuel becomes even stronger when compared with the current EV transition narrative. Electric vehicles will certainly be part of India's long-term future, but the present reality is more complicated. A large share of the EV ecosystem still depends on imported cells, batteries, motors and magnets. Out of 49 EV passenger vehicle models currently available in India, only six meet the 40 percent local value-add threshold of Performance Linked Incentive schemes.

So the danger is obvious: a rapid move to EVs today may not eliminate import dependence at all. It may simply shift it from the Middle East to China and the restriction of Chinese rare-earth magnets last year was no less impactful to EVs as the Straits of Hormuz closure has been to internal combustion engine vehicles.

That is why India needs a broader fuel strat-



THE GOVERNMENT SHOULD THEREFORE STOP TREATING FLEX-FUEL AS A SIDE BRANCH OF THE ETHANOL STORY. IT SHOULD BE THE MAIN ROAD AHEAD.

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egy, not a narrow one. Ethanol and flex-fuel deserve more serious support because they are rooted in Indian agriculture, Indian biomass and Indian industrial capability. They convert surplus grain, molasses, maize and agricultural residue into transport energy. They keep more value inside the country. They reduce pressure on crude imports. And they offer a path that is both practical and sovereign.

The Automotive Industry is right to ask for policy support to make this shift possible. If flex-fuel is to become a mass-market technology, it will need lower GST or some other form of fiscal encouragement. It will also need fuel economics that make sense. E85 or E100 must be meaningfully cheaper than petrol, ideally by at least 30%, if consumers are to see a real reason to switch. Nobody buys into a new fuel system because it sounds patriotic. People switch when the economics, convenience and availability all line up.

That is why the government's policy direction matters so much. NITI Aayog's recent report is important because it includes biofuel-based vehicles in the definition of Zero Emission Vehicles for the first time. That is a significant shift in thinking. It shows that the policy establishment is beginning to understand that India's mobility transition will not be a straight line from petrol to battery.

The report's sequencing is also sensible. It recommends first phasing out the most polluting diesel vehicles and moving toward lower-emission options such as CNG, hybrids and EVs. The next phase should expand bio-

fuels through flex-fuel vehicles, high bio-CNG blends and hybrid FFV models, while EV adoption continues. The final phase should move toward full deployment of Zero Emission Vehicles, including EVs, hydrogen vehicles, FFVs and CBG-based models, with segment-specific targets and compliance timelines.

That is a realistic roadmap, not a slogan.

And realism is the point. India's transition cannot be powered by one technology alone. It needs a portfolio. EVs will matter. Hybrids will matter. CNG and biogas will matter. But flex-fuel deserves a central place in that mix because it can turn India's biomass advantage into transport energy now, not at some distant future date.

That is the larger strategic gain. India has the agricultural base, biomass potential and industrial depth to produce fuel domestically at scale. Ethanol gives that potential an outlet. It uses surplus and residue more productively. It supports rural incomes. It keeps more of the energy value chain within India. And it reduces dependence on imported crude at a time when that dependence is increasingly risky.

The government should therefore stop treating flex-fuel as a side branch of the ethanol story. It should be the main road ahead. That means fiscal support for FFVs, clear pricing for E85 and E100, and a serious market-building strategy that gives both consumers and manufacturers confidence. India does not need more halfway solutions. It needs a policy that can carry the weight of its ambitions. Flex-fuel is that policy.

The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

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The writer is an educator and a councillor

Why quality teachers are hard to find?



SAKSHI SETHI

2ND OPINION

Education is often described as the backbone of a nation's development, and teachers are the pillars that support this foundation. Yet, despite the importance of their role, schools across the country are facing a growing challenge - attracting and retaining qualified teachers. Beneath impressive academic results, school rankings, and rising expectations lies a troubling reality: teaching, once considered one of the most respected professions, is steadily losing its appeal among talented young professionals.

The problem extends far beyond unfilled vacancies. It reflects the widening gap between what society expects from teachers and the conditions under which they are expected to work. Over the years, the role of educators has expanded dramatically. A modern teacher is no longer limited to classroom instruction. Teachers today are

expected to be mentors, counsellors, administrators, event managers, technology experts, and emotional support systems for both students and parents.

At the same time, their workload has increased significantly. While professional development is necessary for improving education standards, the constant demands often leave little time for creativity, personal well-being, or meaningful engagement with students.

One of the most pressing concerns remains the issue of compensation. Teachers shoulder immense responsibility in shaping young minds, yet salaries in many institutions fail to reflect the effort, expertise, and emotional investment required by the profession. In comparison, the corporate sector generally offers better salaries, performance incentives, flexible work environments, and clearer opportunities for career growth. Employees in corporate jobs often receive recognition for their achievements and enjoy more defined professional boundaries.

Teachers, however, frequently work beyond official hours without adequate compensation. Correcting notebooks late at night, preparing lessons on weekends, organising school events, and managing administrative work have become accepted parts of the profession. Such an imbalance naturally discourages many capable graduates from choosing teaching as a

career. Young professionals with strong communication skills, leadership qualities, and subject expertise increasingly prefer corporate careers that promise financial stability, recognition, and work-life balance. Another major challenge is the pressure to constantly deliver measurable results. Teachers are judged not only by their teaching abilities but also by student performance, parent expectations, school reputation, and institutional targets. The rapid integration of technology has added further responsibilities. Teachers are expected to continuously adapt to digital platforms, smart classrooms, and online assessments, often without sufficient support or time. Alongside this, they quietly carry the emotional burden of supporting anxious students and managing behavioural issues. Despite these difficulties, countless teachers continue to serve with dedication and sincerity. However, commitment alone cannot sustain a profession indefinitely. If society truly values education, it must value educators through better salaries, healthier working conditions, mental wellness support, and professional respect. After all, no education system can rise above the quality of its teachers, and neglecting them ultimately means risking the future of an entire generation.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Biodiversity protection is essential for survival

Human beings cannot remain passive spectators when it comes to environmental protection because nature is deeply connected to the survival of all living beings. Clean air, biodiversity conservation, ecosystem restoration and sustainable use of resources are all essential for maintaining a healthy environment. A balanced ecosystem, made up of plants, animals, fungi and microorganisms, strengthens productivity and ensures long-term sustainability. The devastating coronavirus pandemic has also highlighted the consequences of disturbing ecological balance. Deforestation, destruction of wildlife habitats, climate change and uncontrolled urban expansion have increased interactions between humans and wild animals, creating pathways for dangerous viral transmissions. The chain is clear: habitat destruction leads to increased human-animal contact, which eventually raises the risk of infectious diseases spreading to humans. Over the last fifty years, the world has lost nearly half of its natural resources due to reckless exploitation and environmental neglect. Sustainable development requires maintaining a careful balance between consumption and conservation. Protecting biodiversity is no longer merely an environmental issue; it is essential for human health, economic stability and the future of the planet itself.

GANAPATHI BHAT | AKOLA

Building a smarter power network

India's rapidly growing electricity demand underlines the urgent need to modernise and strengthen the country's power infrastructure. Merely increasing energy production is not enough to guarantee uninterrupted supply unless transmission and distribution networks are efficient, reliable and technologically advanced.

Frequent power outages, overloaded transformers and transmission losses continue to inconvenience households and disrupt industries, particularly during periods of extreme weather. The focus must now shift towards creating intelligent and adaptable power systems capable of responding quickly to fluctuations in demand and supply. Greater use of automation, smart grids, data analytics and energy storage technologies can significantly improve efficiency while reducing wastage.

Encouraging rooftop solar adoption and enabling households or local communities to feed surplus electricity back into the grid can also reduce pressure on conventional systems. A modern electricity network is necessary for sustaining industrial growth and economic development. As India moves towards cleaner and more sustainable sources of power, strengthening the backbone of the electricity sector must become a national priority for long-term progress and resilience.

VANDANA | CHANDIGARH

Political Optics and Public Priorities

The recent exchange between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Italian Prime Minister Giorgia Meloni over Melody chocolates has once again triggered political debate and social media frenzy. The "Melodi" phrase, coined from the surnames of the two leaders during the COP28 summit in Dubai, resurfaced after a video shared by Meloni showed PM Modi gifting her a packet of Melody candies. While the moment was widely circulated online, it also invited criticism from the Opposition.

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi questioned the timing and optics of such gestures, arguing that the country is facing serious economic concerns. Referring to rising inflation, unemployment and the struggles of farmers, workers and small traders, Gandhi alleged that symbolic public relations exercises cannot distract from pressing economic challenges. He also linked the issue to the Prime Minister's recent appeal urging citizens to adopt austerity measures. Political leaders often use public diplomacy and personal gestures to build international goodwill. However, critics argue that governance must remain focused on addressing domestic hardships and economic anxieties. The controversy reflects how even seemingly light-hearted moments can become politically charged in a deeply polarised environment.

BHAGWAN THADANI | PUNE

PIC TALK



A purple sunbird perches on a branch of Samanea Saman tree, commonly known as monkey pod tree, in New Delhi,

PHOTO: PTI

DIGITAL EXPERIENCE



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REFORMING SIVAKASI FIREWORKS INDUSTRY

Sivakasi's fireworks industry, which powers India's festive celebrations and provides livelihoods to thousands, continues to witness tragic accidents with alarming regularity.

Despite repeated judicial interventions over the past decade – including restrictions on hazardous chemicals and the push for green crackers – fatal explosions remain a grim reality. The recurring deaths and injuries reveal deep-rooted systemic failures that can no longer be ignored.

The very nature of fireworks manufacturing involves handling volatile chemicals under dangerous conditions, especially during peak summer months when high temperatures increase the risk of combustion. However, climate alone cannot explain the

scale of devastation. Reports submitted before the National Green Tribunal indicate that more than 130 people have lost their lives and nearly 90 have been injured since 2022. Such statistics point towards inadequate safety standards, poor monitoring and insufficient worker protection. The industry urgently requires comprehensive reforms. Strict enforcement of safety regulations, modern manufacturing practices, regular inspections and proper training for workers are essential.

At the same time, businesses must adopt sustainable and responsible production methods. Protecting workers' lives should be treated as a priority, not an afterthought, if the industry is to survive with credibility and public trust.

JAYANTHY SUBRAMANIAM | MUMBAI

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

Reclaiming the sacred: Ancient Indian wisdom for today's environmental challenges

Delhi's water future depends on what we do today!

From the Vedas to the Bhagavad Gita, Indian civilisation has long viewed the Earth, rivers, forests and animals as sacred and interconnected with human existence. In an era of ecological crisis, these timeless values may hold important lessons for building a more sustainable and harmonious future.



VINAYAK
RAJAT BHAT

The world today is facing serious environmental challenges. Pollution, climate change, deforestation, and the loss of biodiversity are no longer distant concerns—they are realities we experience every day. Rivers are becoming polluted, forests are shrinking, and many species are disappearing at an alarming rate. Governments and global institutions have introduced laws and policies, such as environmental protection acts and carbon credit systems, to address these issues. While these measures are necessary, they often fall short of creating lasting change.

The main reason is that these solutions depend largely on social enforcement rather than inner motivation. People may follow rules when they are monitored, but real and lasting change happens only when individuals feel a sense of responsibility from within. What is needed is a cultural and ethical foundation that inspires people to care for nature willingly. This is where ancient Indian wisdom becomes highly relevant.

Indian tradition offers a powerful perspective. It teaches us to see nature not as a resource to be exploited, but as something sacred and deeply connected to our lives. This shift—from control to reverence—can transform how we approach environmental protection.

A Worldview Rooted in Unity

In ancient Indian thought, especially in the Vedas, nature is not separate from human life. It is an integral part of existence. The basic elements of nature—Ether, fire, air, water, and earth—were respected and even worshipped because they sustain life.

Akasa (Ether), Agni (fire), Vayu (air), and Apah (water) were treated as divine forces. This was not blind ritualism but a way of reminding people of their importance and encouraging respect.

The Earth itself was seen as a nurturing mother. The Atharvaveda describes Earth as "Vasudha," the one who supports all living beings. A powerful verse says: "O earth! The beings who are born on you travel over you. For the four-legged animals and two-legged humans you nurture, the sun spreads the nectar light throughout its rays throughout its rays." - (Atharvaveda 12.1.15)

This idea is deeply meaningful. It tells us that humans are not the sole owners of the planet. Animals, birds, and all creatures have equal rights over it. This perspective is especially important today, when human activity is destroying habitats and threatening biodiversity.

This vision is further expressed in the phrase "vasudevah kutumbh"—the world is one family. If we truly accept this idea, then harming nature would feel like harming our own family members.

Lessons in Leadership from Indian Traditions

Indian scriptures and stories provide practical examples of how these values can be applied. The life of Sri Krishna offers important lessons in environmental responsibility.

In the story of Kaliya-Mardana, the serpent Kaliya had poisoned the Yamuna river. Krishna did not ignore the problem. He took responsibility, confronted the source of pollution, and restored the river.

In today's context, Kaliya can represent industries or activities that pollute our environment. The lesson is clear: leadership is tested in moments that demand timely action. Another important episode is the worshipping of the Govardhana mountain. Krishna encouraged people to honour the mountain that directly supported their lives, rather than focusing only on distant forces. This story is very relevant today. Modern development often damages mountains and ecosystems, leading to floods and landslides. The Govardhana episode reminds us that nature sustains us, and we must protect it.

The Bhagavad Gita expresses this idea of mutual care:



INDIAN TRADITION OFFERS A POWERFUL PERSPECTIVE. IT TEACHES US TO SEE NATURE NOT AS A RESOURCE TO BE EXPLOITED, BUT AS SOMETHING SACRED AND DEEPLY CONNECTED TO OUR LIVES

"By supporting one another, you shall attain the highest good." - (Bhagavad Gita 3.11)

This highlights that human well-being and environmental well-being are mutually dependent.

Respect for Nature in Daily Life

Indian culture brings environmental awareness into everyday life through symbols and practices. Rivers like the Ganga are worshipped as goddesses, and mountains like the Himalayas are considered sacred. These beliefs create a sense of respect and responsibility. When people see nature as sacred, they are more likely to protect it. This mantra Rigveda of presents the same:

Imam me gange yamune Sarasvati sutudri sacata parusnya |

Asiknya marudvrdhe vitastayarjikiye sruhya susomaya || (Rigveda: 10.75.5)

O Ganga yamuna saraswati shatadru and parushni, receive my prayers. o maruda, joined by the asikni with asta and arjikiya by the sushma hear my prayers. Rituals like the Ganga Arati and gatherings such as the Kumbhamela reinforce this connection and remind people of the importance of keeping natural resources clean.

Animals are also given respect. Many deities are associated with animal vehicles—Siva with the bull, Vishnu with the eagle, and Skanda with the peacock. These symbols show that animals are part of the sacred order of life. Even natural enemies are shown coexisting peacefully in divine imagery, representing harmony in nature. The early incarnations of Lord Vishnu—as a fish, tortoise, boar, and half-lion—also convey that divinity exists in all forms of life. This encourages respect for biodiversity.

Environmental Responsibility as a Daily Practice

Ancient Indian tradition emphasises daily responsibility through the concept of the Panca Maha-yajnas, or five duties. Among them is Bhuta Yajna, which focuses on caring for other living beings. This can be practised through simple acts—feeding animals, planting trees, or avoiding harm to nature. This idea holds great significance in today's context. Environmental protection is often seen as a large issue, but Bhuta Yajna shows that small daily actions also matter. When practised collectively, they can create meaningful change.

A Way Forward

Modern science and policies are essential for solving environmental problems, but they need to be supported by a strong ethical foundation. Ancient Indian wisdom provides this foundation. It encourages respect, balance, and responsibility by teaching us to see the Earth as a mother and all beings as part of one family.

The goal is not to replace modern solutions but to complement them. By combining traditional values with contemporary approaches, we can create a more sustainable future. Education and public awareness can play an important role in bringing these ideas into practice. In the end, solving environmental challenges is not just about laws and technology—it is about changing our mindset.

When we begin to see nature as sacred, protecting it becomes a natural part of life. Ancient Indian wisdom offers a timeless guide for this transformation. By rediscovering these values, we can move towards a future that is not only sustainable but also deeply meaningful.



UMANG BAJAJ

Every year, Delhi faces the same issues in summer -- rising temperatures, increasing demand for water, and stress on the water resources of the city. What is new about the issue today is the seriousness of the efforts to solve the problems effectively.

To understand the challenge better, it is essential to focus on the basic problem that Delhi faces every year in relation to water. While the demand increases in summer, the water supply in the city remains the same. This makes it important to look at ways to better manage the city's supply requirements.

A considerable amount of the city's water requirement is fulfilled by north Indian rivers. Over the years, these rivers have come under increasing strain. Pollution, untreated waste, encroachment, and shrinking river flows have all reduced both the quantity and quality of water available.

It has also become critical to see the bigger picture here with reference to our environment. Low snowfall in the Himalayas due to climate change impacts our sources of water directly and highlights the need to look at measures on a large scale. We need to be ready for both the present and the future.

In such a situation, it is worth noting that a new approach to resolving the water problem is emerging. Though Delhi has received abundant rains in the monsoon period for many years, the runoff from this monsoon water was not being used and was allowed to drain away.

At the same time, there were problems related to floods and a shortage of water in the summer months. It had become important to address this issue, which is the focus of current policymaking. It is for this reason that rainwater harvesting has gained significance as an important area of policy implementation.

The concept of rainwater harvesting is very clear and easy to understand. The objective behind it is to conserve rainwater in its place and recharge it into the ground-water, thus addressing the problem of floods and ensuring water security by minimising dependency on external water.

This is a positive trend, as it is no longer merely a suggestion but something that is enforced. The government has established deadlines for achieving compliance with installing the rainwater harvesting systems before the onset of the monsoon season for government properties, parks, residential areas, and campuses. Accountability appears to be at the heart of this initiative.



It is worth noting here that the Delhi Jal Board has played an instrumental role in enforcing rainwater harvesting by providing financial incentives to encourage compliance. Incentives such as rebates for installation of the system have been proposed along with stricter compliance procedures. Self-certification has also been proposed as another mechanism of compliance and long-term accountability of property owners.

That said a rapid depletion of groundwater resources remains an issue of concern not just in areas around Delhi, but in many other states also. India is among the biggest consumers of groundwater resources in the world. According to estimates, groundwater provides irrigation for about 62% of India's cultivated land, accounts for 85% of rural water needs, and satisfies almost half of urban water demands.

It is due to over-construction, less space available for rainwater to infiltrate, and increased water consumption that depletion of groundwater resources has increased. Thus, it has become critical to conserve groundwater resources. Instead of letting rainwater runoff into storm sewers, it has to be allowed to seep into the ground. For this we are focused on proper planning, monitoring the exploitation of groundwater resources, and safeguarding water bodies.

Meanwhile, as the summer season progresses, the government has implemented its action plan, which includes efficient distribution of water, increased responsiveness to water shortage areas, and better monitoring.

This has enabled the authorities to ensure that people suffer no inconvenience even in peak demand.

Nevertheless, even the most effective initiatives can only work when people equally participate in them. The need for conservation of water should involve everyone. Be it individual homes adopting rainwater harvesting methods or the RWAs and the entire community making sure of its efficient use, each step is significant. Ultimately, the goal should be to make water conservation a mass movement in Delhi. In this process, the communities and the RWAs can be a very valuable partner of the government and work collectively to make it a success.

Rainwater harvesting and other water conservation methods are the way to go. In addition, we need strict policies to enforce them and citizen participation to ensure water security.

While the problem may be difficult, solutions still exist. It is through proper planning and teamwork only that we can ensure the city does not face any future water shortages.

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Urja Atmanirbharta: Why India must accelerate the CBG revolution



AKANSHA JAIN

Prime Minister Narendra Modi, addressing a rally in Hyderabad on May 10, made an extraordinary appeal: skip buying gold for weddings this year. Defer that overseas holiday and work from home as much as possible. The fact that a sitting PM is asking ordinary citizens to alter personal decisions because the national balance sheet is under strain is deeply concerning. And when a leader of Modi's stature makes that kind of appeal, the underlying economics must be genuinely alarming.

India imports nearly 88% of its crude oil and 60% of its LPG, and the overwhelming bulk of it flows through the 33-kilometre-wide Strait of Hormuz. Since early March 2026, that strait has been effectively blocked following the escalation of the US-Israel conflict with Iran. The consequences for India have been swift and severe: LPG supplies fell to more than 40% of normal capacity, the Essential Commodities Act was invoked, commercial kitchens in Mumbai shuttered, hotels in Bengaluru received barely 10% of their gas allocations, and the rupee came under sustained depreciation pressure. The economics of this crisis have been brutal so far, with every \$10 rise in crude oil prices adding \$13-14 billion to India's annual oil import

bill. As the Brent crude prices touched \$130 per barrel at the peak of the crisis, India has been haemorrhaging foreign exchange at a rate that no amount of RBI intervention can fully neutralise. Thus, PM's appeal to reduce gold imports (a massive dollar drain), comes under this scenario. The messaging is clear: the import bill is now structurally unsustainable, and the government is urgently searching for room to breathe.

As T.S Eliot famously quoted, "Home is where one starts", and so in this case, the search must begin closer to home as well. India has, largely untapped, one of the largest natural biogas reserves in the world. Agricultural residues from paddy, wheat, and sugarcane up to 500 million tonnes annually; cattle dung from 300 million bovines, municipal solid waste from a rapidly urbanising population of 1.4 billion and tonnes of food processing waste from one of the world's largest agro-economies, a huge scale of waste, but when fed into anaerobic digesters, they produce biogas. This biogas, when purified and compressed, becomes Compressed Biogas (CBG), chemically identical to CNG, compatible with existing gas pipelines, buses, industrial boilers, and domestic PNG connections.

India's technical potential for CBG production is estimated at up to 90 billion cubic metre equivalents annually. To put that in perspective: India's total LNG import dependence of 27-29 million tonnes per annum could be substantially offset if even a fraction of this potential were realised. CBG carries zero geopolitical risk, as its feedstock grows in Indian fields, not in the Gulf. Yet as of



late 2025, India had barely 130 operational CBG plants, against a SATAT programme target of 5,000. Despite the resource availability, policy execution is a problem, and now the Hormuz crisis has made the cost of that underperformance visible in hard-dollar terms.

What makes CBG scale-up so compelling is that it is a convergence of several of India's most pressing developmental needs. Firstly, every tonne of CBG that displaces imported LNG or LPG is a dollar that stays inside India's reserves. At current import prices and crisis-level crude, that is a significant macro relief. A CBG sector at even 30% of its potential could take measurable pressure off the current account deficit.

Second, is the farmer's dividend. CBG's primary

feedstocks, such as paddy straw, cattle dung, and press mud from sugar mills, are either wasted or actively destructive today. Stubble burning across Punjab and Haryana each October chokes Delhi with smog. Converting that residue into CBG feedstock creates a new income stream for farmers, a new industrial anchor for rural districts, and an end to one of India's most politically intractable environmental crises in a single stroke.

Third, the slurry produced as a byproduct of CBG digestion is a rich, slow-release bio-fertiliser, a direct substitute for imported urea. The Hormuz crisis has already pushed global urea prices up by 50% since the Gulf states account for nearly a third of world production. A mature CBG sector would produce fermented organic manure at scale, closing a loop that currently runs from Indian agriculture to Gulf fertiliser plants and back again at enormous dollar cost, ensuring food security.

While there is policy in place, the gap between the policy and the plant needs to be urgently bridged. Amidst the blending mandate and actually getting the molecule to the pipeline, India has already lost a decade, and of course, a lot of dollars. What India needs now is to set out existing programmes to work at the pace the crisis demands. This means mapping the available feedstocks to categorise which ones are suitable for CBG production; investing in making feedstock aggregation, supply chain and storage; clear instructions on mandates, clearances, subsidies, implementation mechanisms, which are lacking currently due to multiple ministries; and lastly treating CBG not just as a peripheral green

initiative but as a core supply-chain imperative. It also means state governments, enacting their own CBG policies with real Viability Gap Funding. And it means the blending mandate is being enforced with the same rigour as the ethanol blending targets have been pursued.

With no major Assembly elections due until early 2027, the Centre has a rare five-to-six-month runway to take decisions that are economically necessary but short-term painful. Fuel price adjustments, investment in supply-side infrastructure, and acceleration of CBG commissioning are easier when the electoral calendar provides breathing room.

The Hormuz crisis, for all its enormous costs, has done one useful thing: it has made the price of India's energy dependency impossible to ignore. The PM has acknowledged the problem publicly, in the plainest possible language. The next step must move from restraint, asking citizens to do less, to acceleration, asking the state to build faster. Every methane molecule that rises from India's fields and reaches the atmosphere is a failure of both policy and imagination. Every one that reaches a gas pipeline is a dollar saved, a farmer paid, and a degree of sovereignty reclaimed, in true sense Urja Atmanirbharta (energy self-reliance) attained!

Dr Akanksha Jain is a research consultant at the Centre for Climate Change and Energy Transition (CCET) at Chintan Research Foundation (CRF).

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Order Order

HC reserves order on exemption to slaughter rules for Eid

The Calcutta High Court on Thursday reserved judgment on a bunch of petitions challenging a recent West Bengal government notification on animal slaughter during next week's Eid al-Adha. The petitioners sought an exemption under Section 12 of the Animal Slaughter Control Act, 1950, for performing the religious rituals during the festival. Senior lawyer Bikash Ranjan Bhattacharya, appearing for one petitioner, submitted before the court that the Act was framed in 1950, when agriculture was dependent on domestic animals, but at present, farming is technology-driven. He stated that section 12 of the Act provides for relaxation for religious purposes. (PTI)



Have asked all HCs to conduct online hearings: CJI

Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant on Thursday said he has asked all high courts across the country to conduct hearings online and most of them have already implemented it. The observation came when a lawyer mentioned a plea before a bench headed by the CJI seeking an urgent hearing of her plea that all Delhi courts should go online. "I have already requested the Chief Justices. Most have already implemented. It has to be a voluntary exercise by both the Bar and the Bench," CJI Kant said. The lawyer told the apex court that in her plea, she has sought directions to all district courts to conduct hearings online for three months in the interest of the nation. The CJI then said, "District courts are the domain of High Courts. District courts are in the administrative domain of HCs. Let them take call... I have requested them for district courts also." (PTI)



BCI moves SC to finalise 10% co-option formula for women in State bar councils

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Bar Council of India (BCI) has moved the Supreme Court seeking approval for a merit-based "co-option" mechanism to ensure 30 per cent women's representation in state bar councils. The BCI, the apex bar body, has proposed to fill a 10-per cent co-option quota by selecting women candidates who have secured the highest number of votes among those not elected, rather than through subjective appointments. The proposal aims to complement the 20 per cent seats reserved for women through direct election, bringing the



total representation to the 30-per cent mandate previously set by the apex court. BCI chairperson and senior advocate Manan Kumar Mishra, in a statement, said the bar body has considered the submissions made by



Exclusion of heirs not enough to invalidate will: SC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Noting that the very purpose of a will is to alter the normal line of succession, the Supreme Court on Thursday said that merely excluding natural heirs from inheritance cannot by itself be treated as a suspicious circumstance to invalidate a will. A bench of Justices Ujjal Bhuyan and Vijay Bishnoi dismissed an appeal filed by the wife and children of late B Sheena Nairi challenging the validity of a will through which the deceased had bequeathed his properties in Karnataka to his sister Laxmi Nairithy. The top court upheld concurrent findings of the trial



court, the appellate court and the Karnataka High Court, which had accepted the will as genuine. "The exclusion of the natural heirs cannot be sufficient to vitiate the will in

question, particularly when the will clearly specifies that the testator has not done any injustice to his wife, children, or other relatives, and that he has given enough to his wife and children who are residing

at Bombay," the court said. The dispute arose after B Sheena Nairi, a chartered accountant, executed a will in May 1983 in favour of his younger sister and died later that year. His wife and chil-

dren challenged the document, alleging it was fabricated and contending that they had been unfairly deprived of inheritance. "Mere exclusion of the natural heirs from the property of the testator, by itself, cannot be construed as a suspicious circumstance so as to invalidate a will outright," the court said. The bench noted that the will itself recorded that the testator had already given "enough and more" to his wife and children residing in Bombay. The court also reiterated the legal principles governing proof of wills and held that the document stood duly proved through the testimony of an attesting

witness, who confirmed that the testator had executed and signed the will in his presence. "A testator is legally entitled to dispose of his property according to his own wishes, and unless the exclusion is accompanied by suspicious circumstances affecting the genuineness or due execution of a will, such exclusion alone does not render a will invalid," the court said. The bench further held that mutation entries in revenue records do not confer title and are merely for fiscal purposes. Dismissing the appeal, the bench held that the findings of all courts upholding the validity of the will did not warrant interference.

Court convicts three for rioting, unlawful assembly

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

A Delhi court has convicted three men in a case related to the 2020 northeast Delhi riots, saying that the prosecution successfully proved they were part of an unlawful assembly that pelted stones at police and obstructed officials on duty during the violence at Khajuri Khas. Additional Sessions Judge Parveen Singh was hearing a case against Ikram, Sarfaraz and Mustaqueem accused of rioting, unlawful assembly and assault on public servants, and said that evidence established their guilt in the case.



In an order dated May 18, the court said, "The evidence on record clearly establishes that throughout the relevant period, the unlawful

assembly was continuously indulging in stone pelting upon the police force, thereby obstructing public servants in discharge of

their duties and causing injuries to several police personnel." According to prosecution, the three persons were accused of being part of violence that erupted on February 24, 2020, near Bhajanpura police booth and Karawal Nagar Road in northeast Delhi during the riots, where an unruly mob allegedly set ablaze shops, carts and a police both and pelted stones at police personnel. It was alleged that the police officials patrolling the area repeatedly asked people to disperse and announced prohibitory orders before the crowd turned violent. Several policemen were injured in the clashes.



HC GRANTS BAIL TO SALIM MALIK IN UAPA CASE

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Thursday granted bail to Salim Mailk in a case under anti-terror law UAPA concerning the "larger conspiracy" behind the February 2020 riots in the city's north-eastern parts. The relief was granted by a bench of Justices Prathiba M Singh and Madhu Jain on Malik's appeal challenging a trial court order of January 29 that denied him bail in the case. His counsel argued that he was entitled to bail in view of the Supreme Court granting the relief to identically-placed co-accused Saleem Khan and Shadab Ahmed. Malik was booked under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA) for being one of the "master-minds" of the February 2020 riots that had left 53 people dead and more than 700 injured. The violence erupted during protests against the Citizenship (Amendment) Act (CAA), 2019, and the National Register of Citizens (NRC). Salim, who was arrested in June 2020, is among the 11 alleged organisers and speakers of an anti-CAA/NRC meeting. On January 5, the Supreme Court granted bail to five accused — Gulfshifa Fatima, Meeran Haider, Shifa Ur Rehman, Mohammad Saleem Khan and Shadab Ahmad — in the 2020 Delhi riots conspiracy case. The top court, however, denied the relief to activists Umar Khalid and Sharjeel Imam, saying all the accused in the case do not stand on the same footing. On September 2, 2025, a bench of Justices Navin Chawla and Shalinder Kaur had denied bail to Imam, Khalid, Haider and other co-accused in the case.

CJI urged to retract observations against environment activists

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A group of 72 lawyers, law students, law faculty, law researchers, and activists trained in law have written an open letter to Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant, demanding a retraction of the Supreme Court's recent observations on the practice of filing pleas to stall developmental projects. A Bench comprising the

CJI and Justice on May 11 had said, "Show us even a single project in this country where these alleged environmental activists have said that we welcome this project." The letter, released on Tuesday, states that the observations cast unjust aspersions on concerned citizens, communities and collectives defending the ecology, within the framework of law, statutory institutions, and jurisprudence



evolved by the apex court over decades. The signatories of the letter are members of the National Alliance for Justice, Accountability and

Rights (NAJAR), a platform of law professionals. "We are writing because the observations made extend beyond the outcome in one case. It relates to a broader jurisprudential shift: from viewing environmental litigation as an integral part of constitutional governance towards treating it as a suspect form of obstruction," said the letter. It added that the obser-

vations also pertain to a shift from recognising citizens as enforcers of statutory duties, towards dismissing them as "so-called environmental activists." Also, from subjecting environmental decision-making to rule-of-law scrutiny towards deference to project clearances and administrative expertise, even where the record reveals inconsistencies, omissions and unresolved public concerns.

Calcutta HC grants Abhishek Banerjee protection from coercive action

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

The Calcutta High Court on Thursday granted senior TMC leader Abhishek Banerjee protection from coercive action till July 31 in an FIR over his comments at a public meeting last month, and asked if it was appropriate for a parliamentarian to make unwarranted statements. Justice Saugata Bhattacharyya directed Banerjee, the TMC's national general secretary, to cooperate with the probe and comply with notices sent to him by the investigating officer. The court also directed him not to travel abroad without the leave of the court. The MP from Diamond Harbour moved the high court seeking the quashing of the FIR over his comments against the leaders and workers of a rival party at a public meeting on April 27 in the run-up to the second phase of West Bengal assembly polls.



Asking why "irresponsible statements" were made by Banerjee, Justice Bhattacharyya wondered what would have happened if the TMC won the election. "This state has a very dark history of post-poll violence," he observed. The judge further asked whether Banerjee's comments at the public meeting matched the position of an all-India general secretary of the Trinamool Congress. Granting him protection from coercive action till July 31, the court said it will hear the matter again on July 20.

SC bats for victim-centric approach in fraud cases

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Observing that a victim-centric approach is needed, the Supreme Court on Thursday refused to entertain a plea seeking a direction to club 53 FIRs pending in seven states in relation to alleged duping of ₹49 crore from investors. A bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and Vipul M Pancholi did not agree to the submissions of senior advocate Aman Lekhi, appearing for the accused Upendra Nath Mishra and Kali Prasad Mishra. This led to withdrawal of the plea. Several criminal cases are pending against the accused in Odisha, Chhatisgarh, Jharkhand, Gujarat, Maharashtra, Goa and Andhra Pradesh. Referring to previous apex court judgments which ordered consolidation of FIRs in big fraud cases, the bench said



instead of a victim-centric judicial approach, pro-accused judgments were being passed in the name of consolidation of FIR and speedy trial. "What will happen to the rights of the victims of such crimes," the CJI asked, while refusing to order consolidation of the FIRs. The CJI referred to recent amendments in criminal law and said now the rights of victims have been acknowledged. Every case of fraud is distinct and separate as the victim and the defrauded amount are different, the bench said, adding that, of course, the accused remains the same.

Thin line between defamation, political criticism: Delhi HC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Thursday said there was a thin line between political criticism and defamation, as it asked MP Raghav Chadha if he can be "sensitive" to social media posts seemingly criticizing his "political decision". Chadha, who recently exited the Aam Aadmi Party to join the BJP, filed a lawsuit in the high court against the publication of alleged malicious and fabricated social media posts that, he said, are gravely prejudicial to his reputation and personality rights. Senior advocate Rajiv Nayar, appearing for Chadha, contended there were posts with profane content, including where the politician is shown as having "sold himself away for money". Reserving verdict on the aspect of interim relief to take down such alleged offending content, Justice Subramonium Prasad acknowledged that while an individual has the right to live with dignity, the right to free speech under the Constitution also cannot be taken away. "It is a comment by an individual criticizing a political decision... As a



political leader, can you be sensitive," asked Justice Prasad during the hearing. "Right from Independence, we have grown up seeing RK Laxman's cartoons... In various ways criticism has been made on decisions taken politically, economically... Now social media has gone to greater extent. But still at the end of the day, it's still within the realm of a comment by a person," stated the judge.

Chadha's senior counsel asserted that posts implying he "traded for money" cannot be termed as "fair criticism". Even as Chadha's senior counsel argued that the offending posts "can't stay even for a day", Justice Prasad responded that prima facie they only appeared to be criticism. "According to me, prima facie, these are all only criticism of a political decision," the judge orally said.

SC refuses to lift stay on counting of Delhi Bar Council polls

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Thursday refused to modify its earlier order staying the counting of votes for the Bar Council of Delhi (BCD) elections following tampering allegations and asked the Delhi High Court to hear the pleas on May 25. A bench comprising Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and Vipul M Pancholi was urged by senior advocate Vikas Singh that the May 18 order of the apex court staying the counting of votes be modified. "The counting is underway. Let it be completed. It will not be released subject to the orders of the high court," Singh said, adding that votes are lying scattered and it raises the issue of tampering of votes. "We will not modify our order... there are serious issues (with regard to BCD elections)," the CJI said, referring to allegations that tampered ballot papers were being counted. "On mentioning the MA (miscellaneous application) taken on board, since the matter is urgent, we request the Delhi High Court Chief Justice to list the matter immediately on Monday before a



Division Bench. Parties shall be at liberty to present all arguments," the bench ordered. On May 18, the bench stayed the counting of votes for the BCD elections. The CJI transferred the matter to a division bench of the Delhi High Court, urging the chief justice to constitute a special bench to hear the dispute on a day-to-day basis. The Supreme Court said it had received a letter in a sealed cover from former HC judge Talwant Singh on May 2 relating to the election process and ordered that it be resealed and sent to the chief justice of the high court.

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Stock markets end marginally lower in volatile trade

BSE SENSEX

MAY 21, 2026

CHANGE: -135.03 (-0.18%)

Previous Close

75,318.39

Today's Closing

75,183.36

75,183.36

75,318.39

9 am

11 am

1 pm

3 pm

4 pm

INDIGO +3.25%

BEL +1.77%

TRENT +1.76%

ADANI PORTS +1.12%

TATA STEEL +0.72%

TOP GAINERS

↑

BAJAJ FINANCE -1.74%

HINDUSTAN UNILEVER -1.37%

TECH MAHINDRA -1.36%

INFOSYS -1.27%

BAJAJ FINSERV -1.16%

TOP LOSERS

↓

Equity benchmark indices ended lower in a volatile day of trade on Thursday, surrendering their early gains, amid profit-taking in blue-chip stocks.

The 30-share BSE Sensex declined 135.03 points, or 0.18 per cent, to settle at 75,183.36. During the day, it hit a high of 75,945.79 and a low of 74,996.78, gyrating 949.01 points.

The 50-share NSE Nifty skidded 4.30 points, or 0.02 per cent, to end at 23,654.70.

From the 30-Sensex firms, Bajaj Finance, Tech Mahindra, Hindustan Unilever, Infosys, Bajaj Finserv and Bharti Airtel were among the major laggards.

InterGlobe Aviation, Trent, Bharat Electronics and Adani Ports were among the winners.

"Indian equity markets witnessed another volatile session today, with benchmark indices surrendering their strong opening gains as positive global cues collided with persistent macroeconomic concerns and strong resistance at higher levels," Hariprasad K, Research Analyst and Founder, Livelong Wealth, said.

Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, declined 0.71 per cent to USD 104.3 per barrel level.

In Asian markets, South Korea's benchmark Kospi and Japan's Nikkei 225 index ended higher. The Kospi surged over 8 per cent.

Shanghai's SSE Composite index and Hong Kong's Hang Seng index ended lower.

Markets in Europe were trading in positive territory. US markets ended significantly higher on Wednesday.

Foreign Institutional Investors (FIIs) offloaded equities worth ₹1,597.35 crore on Wednesday, according to exchange data.

On Wednesday, the 30-share BSE benchmark climbed 117.54 points, or 0.16 per cent, to settle at 75,318.39. The Nifty edged higher by 41 points, or 0.17 per cent, to end at 23,659. (PTI)

GST: Businesses can digitally record 'goods delivered'

GST registered businesses can now digitally record delivery of goods for which a e-way bill was generated on the portal, GST Network said.

In an advisory to taxpayers, GSTN, which manages the tech backbone of goods and services tax (GST) said, "A new e-way bill closure facility has been introduced in the e-way bill system on voluntary basis to enable closure of the e-way bill once delivery of goods is completed."

Until now, the e-way bill framework primarily tracked initiation and transit of goods movement, but lacked a formal mechanism to digitally record completion of delivery. This closure feature would create a clearer end-to-end transaction trail and strengthens logistical accountability. Under GST, a person carrying goods valued over ₹50,000 has to carry an e-way bill. The document is required to be generated from the GST Portal by a GST-registered person or transporter before transporting the goods.

The GSTN said e-way bill may be closed by either supplier, or recipient, or transporter involved in the transaction, or driver or any authorised person whose mobile number has been provided for closure.

It further said the changes are being implemented in the e-way bill system with a view to strengthening data integrity, improving traceability of goods movement, and enabling system-driven closure of transactions.

It also asked taxpayers, transporters, ERP/API integrators, and other stakeholders to initiate necessary system readiness measures.

AMRG Global Managing Partner Rajat Mohan said the introduction of the e-way bill closure facility marks an important evolution in GST's digital compliance architecture and businesses with large supply chains should begin evaluating operational readiness early.

While currently introduced as a voluntary mechanism, there is a strong possibility that GSTN may gradually move towards making such closure a mandatory compliance step. If that happens, it could materially strengthen invoice-to-delivery reconciliation and help address concerns around circular trading, round-tripping. (PTI)

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | FRIDAY | MAY 22, 2026

Form JVs with US companies to leverage tech: Gadkari

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Union Minister Nitin Gadkari on Thursday made a case for Indian companies forming joint ventures with US companies to leverage their new technologies.

Addressing AMCHAM's Annual Leadership Summit, Gadkari further said Ministry of Road Transport and Highways is exploring possibilities of taking help of US consultancy companies in preparation of detailed project report (DPR) for road projects.

"India is the fastest growing major economy... the US companies develop lots of new technologies, so

it is very important for Indian companies to have joint venture with US companies," he said.

Noting that supply chain is the most important part in logistics, Gadkari said logistics cost in India has come down to single digit helped by rapid expansion of expressways and economic corridors.

Gadkari further said six months ago, a report prepared by IIT Chennai, IIT Kanpur and IIM Bangalore revealed that India's construction of expressways and economic corridors has helped reduce the country's logistics cost to 10 per cent from 16 per cent earlier.

"India's logistics cost has

now come down to single digit," he said.

Logistics cost is 12 per cent in the US, 12 per cent in

European countries and 8-10 per cent in China.

Talking about India's automobile sector, the minister

US team may visit India next month for trade talks

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The US team is likely to visit India next month for trade talks with their counterparts here, Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal said on Thursday.

The Indian side visited Washington, DC, in April for an in-person round of meetings with their US counterparts to finalise the details of the interim pact and take forward the negotiations under the broader bilateral trade agreement (BTA).

When asked if the US chief negotiator for the BTA will accompany US Secretary of State Marco Rubio, Goyal said "he's not coming with him, but there is some plan for them to come next month".

Rubio will undertake a four-day visit to India beginning May 23 to further cooperation in the fields of trade, defence and energy. This will be his first visit to India.

India and the US issued a joint statement on February 7 finalising a framework for

an interim trade agreement. However, a US Supreme Court ruling struck down all reciprocal tariffs, which had served as the Trump administration's main instrument for negotiating trade deals with partner countries.

Following that, the US

imposed 10 per cent additional duties on all imports under Section 122 of the Trade Act for 150 days from February 24 this year. It also opened two probes under Section 301 of the Act against key exporters for their excess production capacities and labour standards. Under Section 122, tariffs of up to 15 per cent can be imposed for a maximum period of 150 days.

However, under Section 301, there is no cap on the duties that can be levied by the US if investigations conclude that measures adopted by trading partners are harming US interests. India has submitted its response to both the investigations, and consultations between the two sides are underway.

GOLD EXTENDS GAINS FOR THIRD DAY TO ₹1.65 LAKH/10G

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Gold prices rose by ₹600 to ₹1.65 lakh per 10 grams in the national Capital on Thursday, and silver advanced to ₹2.71 lakh per kilogram as traders stayed cautiously optimistic towards precious metals amid geopolitical tensions.

Extending gains for the third straight session, the yellow metal of 99.9 per cent rose ₹600 to ₹1,65,500 per 10 grams (inclusive of all taxes) from Wednesday's closing level of ₹1,64,900, according to local marketmen.

The precious metal has gained ₹2,700 in the past three sessions.

Traders said continued geopolitical tensions in West Asia and concerns over inflation globally supported buying in the metal despite firm US Treasury bond yields.

Silver prices also staged a recovery, jumping ₹5,000 to ₹2,71,000 per kilogram, aided by bargain buying and recovery in industrial demand sentiment, market players said.

Analysts said concerns over the US-Iran conflict and disruptions linked to the Strait of Hormuz continued to underpin demand for the precious metals, and a weaker rupee also supported local prices.

GOLD & SILVER

10g = ₹1,65,500*

1kg = ₹2,71,000*

GOLD 10g

₹1,63,600

GOLD 10g

₹1,64,500

GOLD 10g

₹1,65,500*

SILVER 10g

₹2,67,000

SILVER 10g

₹2,68,000

SILVER 10g

₹2,71,000*

May 19

May 20

May 21

May 19

May 20

May 21

Spot gold prices for 24 carat 10 grams for per 10 grams

Silver prices are national capital for per kg

Source: All India Gems Association

*Provisional

Rupee settles at 96.37 against US dollar

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The rupee rebounded 49 paise from its all-time closing low to settle at 96.37 against the US dollar on Thursday after crude oil prices retreated from elevated levels amid signs of easing geopolitical friction, alongside likely central bank intervention. Forex traders said the rupee had gained after the recent geopolitical developments, but investors are still gauging the geopolitical risk and oil price sensitivity in the background.

The one-year forward market rate for the rupee touched the crucial 100/USD mark on Wednesday, indicating that currency markets are pricing in a weakening bias for the USD/INR pair over the next 12 months, forex traders said.

At the interbank foreign exchange market, the rupee opened at 96.25

RUPEE ₹ VS DOLLAR \$

1 USD = 96.37 INR*

95.64 (+2p)

95.81 (-17p)

96.20 (-39p)

96.70 (-50p)

96.86 (-16p)

96.37* (+49p)

May 14

May 15

May 18

May 19

May 20

May 21

against the dollar, then touched an early high of 96.05 and a low of 96.60 in intraday trade. At the end of Thursday's trading session, the rupee was at 96.37, up 49 paise from its previous closing.

MG Motors sees sharp growth in EV sales

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

MG Motor India, a joint venture between China's SAIC Motor and the Sajjan Jindal-promoted JSW Group, has emerged as a key driver in the country's accelerating electric vehicle (EV) transition. Its sales momentum reflects both rising consumer acceptance and a maturing EV ecosystem. The company reported EV sales of 61,171 units in 2025, more than doubling its 2024 tally of 28,882 units — marking a sharp 111 percent year-on-year growth.

This surge underscores MG's early-mover advantage in India's EV space, supported by a focused portfolio and increasing localisation efforts. Models like the ZS EV and Comet have played a crucial role in broadening appeal across urban buyers, combining practicality with relatively accessible pricing. The growth story has con-

tinued into 2026, albeit at a more measured pace. Between January and April 2026, MG sold 17,539 EVs, compared to 16,220 units during the same period in 2025 — translating to a 9 percent increase, indicat-

ing a gradual stabilisation after a phase of rapid expansion.

Anurag Mehrotra, Managing Director, JSW MG Motor India, said, "We appreciate the Honorable PM's appeal encouraging citizens

said, "Within five years, our target is to make India's automobile industry the number 1 in the world."

"When I took charge as transport minister, the size of the Indian automobile industry was ₹14 lakh crore. It is now ₹22 lakh crore," Gadkari added.

He said the automobile sector provides jobs to 4 lakh youths and the highest GST to the Centre and states. Presently, the size of the US automobile industry is ₹78 lakh crore, followed by China (₹47 lakh crore) and India (₹22 lakh crore).

Gadkari noted that India's dependence on fossil fuels is an economic burden, as ₹22 lakh crore is spent annually

on fuel imports and is an environmental hazard, making the adoption of clean energy crucial for the country's progress.

The minister also said that the government has identified 10 highway stretches in different parts of country for plying green hydrogen-powered trucks with an aim to reduce vehicular pollution.

The identified highway stretches include Greater Noida-Delhi-Agra, Bhubaneswar-Puri-Konark, Ahmedabad-Vadodara-Surat, Sahibabad-Faridabad-Delhi, Jamshedpur-Kalinganagar, Thiruvananthapuram-Kochi, and Jamnagar-Ahmedabad, among others.

GAIL profitability moderated amid global headwinds

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

GAIL (India) Limited on Thursday announced its financial results for the financial year ended March 31, 2026. Financial Performance (Standalone) GAIL reported Revenue from Operations of ₹1,38,697 crore in FY26, as against ₹1,37,288 crore in FY25.

According to a Press release, EBITDA stood at ₹13,119 crore, compared to ₹19,168 crore in the previous year. Profit Before Tax (PBT) for FY26 was ₹8,964 crore, against ₹14,825 crore in FY25. Profit After Tax (PAT) stood at ₹6,968 crore, as compared to ₹11,312 crore in the previous year.

Deepak Gupta, Chairman & Managing Director, GAIL (India) Limited, said the year was marked by a challenging and complex global backdrop, beginning with the ongoing Russia-Ukraine conflict and evolving geopolitical developments including the onset of the West Asian crisis towards the later part of the year.

"Despite these headwinds, supported by timely policy interventions by the Government, GAIL delivered a resilient operational and financial performance. Our teams remained focused on ensuring operational continuity, cost discipline, and supply reliability,

GAIL CMD Deepak Gupta

enabling the Company to effectively navigate a volatile market environment. During the year, we added approximately 2,000 km of pipeline network and achieved the highest-ever LPG transmission of 4.6 MMTPA," the CMD stated.

He further said, GAIL is doubling the capacity of Jamnagar-Loni LPG pipeline to 6.5 MMTPA. "As we advance towards our Strategy 2030 and net-zero commitments, the Company continues to invest in future-ready growth avenues," Gupta said. The Board of Directors has recommended a final dividend of ₹ 0.50 per equity share (face value ₹10 per share) for FY 2025-26, subject to shareholder approval at the forthcoming AGM. This is in addition to the interim dividend of ₹5.00 per share, taking the total dividend payout ratio for the year to 51.90%.

Acharya Balkrishna honoured with Champion Health Award

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Haridwar

Renowned Ayurveda expert Acharya Balkrishna, received the "I AM PEACEKEEPER – Champion Health Award 2026" at the Billionaires for Peace Conclave 2026 in Mumbai. This award recognises his significant contributions to global wellness, humanitarian service, peacebuilding, and the advancement of holistic healthcare through Ayurveda.

This recognition marks a milestone as Ayurveda and India's holistic healthcare traditions gain global traction. Through his visionary leadership, scientific outlook, and tireless efforts, Acharya Balkrishna has helped transform Ayurveda from being viewed merely as a traditional healing practice into a globally notable medical system supported

by modern scientific validation and integrative health research. After receiving the award, Acharya Balkrishna stated that healthy individuals are the foundation of peaceful societies and strong nations. He emphasised that Ayurveda is a comprehensive science of life that guides people toward balance, positivity, and health. He also highlighted India's philosophy of "Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam", the world is one family, and global community's growing interest in India's sustainable solutions for peace and holistic wellbeing.

He further remarked that the modern world is facing an alarming rise in stress, lifestyle disorders, and health-related challenges, and that nature-centric living combined with India's ancient wisdom can offer meaningful solutions. According to

him, Yoga and Ayurveda not only help create a disease-free world, but also contribute towards building a stress-free and conflict-free society.

Acharya Balkrishna described the award as a collective recognition, attributing it to India's cultur-

al heritage, the enduring science of Ayurveda, and all who have embraced natural living to build a healthier, more compassionate society. Over the years, Acharya Balkrishna has played a transformative role in spreading awareness

about preventive healthcare, natural therapies, and holistic wellness at a global level. His efforts have significantly elevated the stature of Ayurveda on the world stage and inspired millions to adopt healthier and more conscious lifestyles. The award ceremony was part of the global "I AM PEACEKEEPER" initiative, which promotes peace, justice, harmony, and humanitarian values. The conclave gathered Nobel Peace Prize laureates, policymakers, industry leaders, spiritual leaders, and global thinkers to discuss peace, human welfare, and sustainable progress.

This honour for Acharya Balkrishna marks a pivotal moment for the Patanjali family, underscoring Ayurveda's growing global influence and the value of holistic wellness for the future of healthcare.

US indicts former Cuban leader; President slams charges

JOSHUA GOODMAN/ALANNA DURKIN RICHER ■ Miami

Federal prosecutors on Wednesday announced criminal charges against former Cuban President Raul Castro in the 1996 downing of civilian planes flown by Miami-based exiles as the Trump administration escalated pressure on the island's socialist Government.

The indictment accuses Castro of ordering the shoot-down of two small planes operated by the exile group Brothers to the Rescue. Castro, who turns 95 next month, was Cuba's defence minister at the time. The charges, which were secretly filed by a grand jury in April, included murder and destruction of an airplane. Five Cuban military pilots were also charged.

"For nearly 30 years, the

families of four murdered Americans have waited for justice," acting Attorney General Todd Blanche said in Miami at a ceremony coinciding with Cuban independence day to honour those killed. "They were unarmed civilians and were flying humanitarian missions for the rescue and protection of people fleeing oppression across the Florida straits."

Asked to what lengths American authorities would go to bring Castro to face charges in the US, Blanche said: "There was a warrant issued for his arrest. So we expect that he will show up here, by his own will or by another way."

Asked what will happen next for Cuba, President Donald Trump said, "We're going to see." He added that the US is ready to provide



Audience members give a standing ovation as Acting Attorney General Todd Blanche (center), speaks at an event where federal prosecutors announced charges against former Cuban President Raul Castro in the 1996 downing of civilian planes operated by Miami-based exiles on Wednesday in Miami

humanitarian assistance to a "failing nation."

The charges pose a real threat, observers said, following the capture by US forces in January of former Venezuelan President

Nicolas Maduro to face drug charges in New York.

"He's going to have to keep his head pretty low from now on," said Peter Kornbluh, a specialist on the US-Cuba relationship at the National

Security Archive at George Washington University.

Cuban president condemns indictment

While it remains unclear whether Castro will ever step foot in a US courtroom, the

murder and conspiracy charges carry the potential for life in prison or the death penalty upon conviction.

Cuban President Miguel Diaz-Canel condemned the indictment as a political stunt that sought only to "justify the folly of a military aggression against Cuba." In a message on social media, he accused the US of lying and manipulating events surrounding the shootdown, including ignoring repeated warnings by Cuban officials at the time that they would defend against "dangerous violations" of their airspace "by notorious terrorists."

Among those attending Wednesday's ceremony in downtown Miami was Marlene Alejandre-Triana, whose father, Armando Alejandre Jr, was killed while she was away for her first year of college.

Over the years, she spoke to multiple federal investigators about charging Castro, referring to him as "one of the main architects of the crime." But none until now had the courage to seek justice for her family and the other victims.

"It has been long overdue," she said standing before a giant photo of her father.

Trump has threatened military action for months Trump has been threatening military action in Cuba ever since US forces captured Maduro, the Cuban Government's long-time patron.

After ousting the Venezuelan leader, the White House ordered a blockade that choked off fuel shipments to Cuba, leading to severe blackouts, food shortages and an economic collapse across the island. (AP)

Nigeria's anti-drug agency shuts down large meth laboratory

OPE ADETAYO ■ Lagos (Nigeria)

Nigeria's anti-drug agency said it has busted a transnational organised drug syndicate involving Nigerians and Mexicans in the southwestern region of the country.

The National Drug Law Enforcement Agency said late Wednesday that its special operations unit shut down "an industrial-scale clandestine laboratory" in a remote forest in the Ijebu area of Ogun state, which shares a border with Lagos, the country's economic capital. The agency added that it is the biggest drug bust ever in the country.

The agency said in a statement that it arrested seven members of the "cartel," which included four Nigerians and three Mexicans, during the operation, and three more in follow-up arrests.

"This network did not just traffic drugs; they were actively manufacturing industrial-scale quantities of highly lethal illicit substances right on our soil, threatening the national security and public health of Nigeria," Brig Gen Mohamed Buba Marwa, the agency's head, said.

According to the statement, the operation resulted in the seizure of 2.4 tons of chemical materials, including methamphetamine, worth 480 billion naira (USD 363 million) and two vehicles.

In recent years, West and Central Africa have emerged as a hot spot for global trafficking and manufacturing of illicit drugs due to porous borders and corruption, according to the United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime. (AP)



A worker carries out confiscated drugs from a warehouse in Lagos, Nigeria

Europe faces stray Ukrainian drones as Kyiv targets Russian oil exports

EMMA BURROWS ■ Kyiv

Over the past months, Ukrainian drones have crashed into the chimney of a power plant in Estonia, hit empty fuel tanks in Latvia and been shot down by Romanian fighter jets stationed in Lithuania.

For the first time in a NATO and European Union capital, Lithuanians were pictured sheltering in underground car parks in Vilnius on Wednesday, as authorities warned of unidentified drone activity.

No one has died or been injured recently, but the

increasing airspace incursions have prompted some Baltic ministers to chastise Ukraine for the violations. In Latvia, officials' handling of the stray drones led to a political crisis that triggered the collapse of the Government earlier this month.

Ukraine has ramped up attacks on Baltic Sea ports used for Russian energy exports in an attempt to hit Moscow's war chest as US President Donald Trump's war in Iran has driven up the price of oil, a key revenue stream for the Kremlin.

As Ukraine's drones have snaked up north, they have

skirted the borders of NATO members Latvia, Lithuania, Estonia and Finland. Some of them were not detected before they crashed and landed in some of the Baltic states.

Ukrainian officials apologised and said the drones were aimed at military targets inside Russia but were sent off course by Russian electronic interference. The string of airspace violations has prompted questions about the state of air defences on NATO's eastern flank.

Ukraine is targeting Russian ports on Baltic Sea

Ukraine's intensifying

attacks against Russia have focused on arms factories, ports on the Baltic Sea and energy facilities as the war in Iran has boosted oil prices.

It has particularly targeted the ports of Ust-Luga and Primorsk, close to the borders of Estonia and Finland. Russia uses the ports to load up ships taking its oil exports through the Baltic Sea.

During one attack in May, which set part of the port of Primorsk on fire, more than 60 Ukrainian drones were shot down, Leningrad region governor Alexander Drozdenko said.

After stray Ukrainian



Ukrainian servicemen of Khartia brigade launch a drone towards Russian positions at the front line in the Kharkiv region, Ukraine

drones entered Latvian airspace on May 7, the country's Defence Minister Andris Spruds resigned, leading Prime Minister Evika

Silina to also quit days later because she was left without a majority in the coalition Government. (AP)

Displaced Lebanese grandmother feeds thousands of compatriots who fled war

MALAK HARB/KAREEM CHEHAYEB ■ Beirut

Even months after she was displaced by war, Soubhiye Zeiter starts every morning the same way: with a large cup of coffee and a few quiet moments beside a small table decorated with flowers outside her tent in Beirut.

But once the coffee is poured, the quiet disappears quickly. By early morning, dozens of people are already lined up outside Zeiter's small bakery stand in a tented settlement in the heart of the Lebanese capital, waiting for her mana'eesh — the popular Lebanese flatbread breakfast topped with cheese, meat or za'atar — a thyme and herb seasoning. Children weave among customers, volunteers rush trays of dough in and out of ovens, and Zeiter, 63, greets



Soubhiye Zeiter (63) a displaced woman who fled her home with her family in Beirut's southern suburbs due to the war between Israel and Hezbollah, distributes mana'eesh, a popular Lebanese flatbread breakfast topped with thyme at a small bakery in a tented settlement along Beirut's waterfront in Lebanon on Thursday

nearly everyone who walks by, often calling people over to sit and have some coffee.

Known to many as Om Mohammed — an Arabic nickname

that means Mohammed's mother — the grandmother fled her home in the southern suburbs of Beirut with 15 members of her family at the start of the war between Israel

and Hezbollah. She was living just south of the capital when the Israeli military issued an evacuation warning to the sprawling neighbourhoods ahead of an intense aerial bombardment.

The ongoing war between Israel and the Hezbollah militant group displaced over one million people in the tiny country during months of cross-border fighting. Many families fled villages in southern Lebanon and Beirut's southern suburbs, seeking shelter in schools, public buildings and tented settlements in Beirut and across the country.

From feeding her family to feeding the community

When Zeiter first arrived at the tented settlement between the Mediterranean Sea and the capital's high-end downtown district, she went to an area nearby

where aid was being distributed. But after being told that she would have to stand in line for hours and still might not receive anything, she decided to make food to feed her family and those in need instead.

She began using her own saj — a traditional round metal griddle used across Lebanon — baking around 200 mana'eesh a day and handing them out for free. As word spread, more people began showing up every morning, some donating ingredients. Soon, the lines stretched longer than she could manage alone.

Now, her small corner of the camp looks more like a neighbourhood bakery. People who heard about what she was doing donated a larger gas-powered oven that hums from early morning until late at night. Dough is rolled through a sheeter. (AP)

Malaysia orders TikTok to explain fake content targeting king

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Kuala Lumpur

Malaysia said Thursday it has ordered TikTok to explain and address what it described as the social media platform's failure to act swiftly against offensive, defamatory and fake content targeting the royal institution.

The Communications and Multimedia Commission said the move followed the circulation of "grossly offensive, false, menacing and insulting" content, including AI-generated videos and manipulated images linked to an account falsely claiming association with king Sultan Ibrahim Iskandar.

Such matters fall within the sensitive issues of race, religion and royalty "which are highly sensitive and may undermine public order, national harmony and respect for constitutional institutions," the regulator said in a statement.

Despite prior notifications and engagements, it said TikTok's moderation response especially in ensuring the prompt removal of such content and preventing further dissemination was unsatisfactory.

It said TikTok — which has not publicly commented on the case — has been issued a legal notice that requires it to explain its moderation failures and undertake immediate remedial measures, including strengthening its content moderation mechanisms and improving enforcement against content that violates Malaysian laws and community standards.

The commission said social media platforms operating in Malaysia are expected to exercise greater responsibility in preventing unlawful and harmful activities on their services. (AP)



The incoming 17th King of Malaysia, the Sultan of Johor, Sultan Ibrahim Iskandar, is seen during welcoming ceremony at National Palace in Kuala Lumpur, Malaysia

Germany urges EU to offer Ukraine 'associate membership' and boost talks with Russia

LORNE COOK/GEIR MOULSON ■ Brussels

German Chancellor Friedrich Merz wants the European Union to consider offering "associate membership" to Ukraine and breathe new life into talks aimed at ending more than four years of war with Russia, according to a letter seen Thursday by *The Associated Press*.

His letter, to the EU's top officials, comes as the 27-nation bloc weighs whether to try to launch its own negotiations with Russian President Vladimir Putin, with US mediated talks bogged down while America's attention focuses



German Chancellor Friedrich Merz (centre) attends the cabinet meeting at the chancellery in Berlin, Germany on Wednesday

on the Iran war.

Under Merz's proposals, Ukraine would take part in EU meetings, but without voting rights, and would also have non-voting "associate members" of the bloc's powerful executive branch, the European Commission, and

the European Parliament.

He insisted that this "would not be a membership light," and "go far beyond" the Association Agreement that currently governs EU-Ukraine relations. Merz suggested a "snap-back mechanism" in

case Ukraine backslides on democratic standards.

European Council President Antonio Costa and European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen reaffirmed last month that official membership talks with Ukraine should be opened "without delay," and Merz too called for that process to start.

Delays and road blocks

On Wednesday, Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy welcomed signs of possible progress in the accession negotiations, saying in an address that it is "very important for us. Ukraine has fulfilled everything necessary for this progress." (AP)



Britain's King Charles III playing a ukulele while meeting members of the Loughries Men's Shed Ukulele Ensemble at Ards Allotments, near Strangford Lough in Newtownards, Northern Ireland on Thursday

Walmart delivers another strong quarter but economic uncertainty clouds outlook for retail sector

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ New York

Walmart delivered another quarter of impressive sales as speedy deliveries and low prices served as a magnet for shoppers across the income spectrum.

Yet like other major retailers posting financial results this week, it was cautious about the rest of the year, given the current economic uncertainty.

On Thursday, it issued a forecast for the current quarter that was weaker than what Wall Street had been expecting. Shares slipped more than 2 per cent before the opening bell on Thursday.

Walmart has resonated with many Americans who are increasingly careful about where they spend their money as inflation has taken a bigger bite out of pay-

checks, particularly since the start of the Iran war in late February. Traffic at Walmart can be a barometer of consumer spending given its vast customer base. More than 150 million customers are on its website or in its stores every week, according to Walmart.

On Thursday, Walmart touted strong sales that were fueled by online shopping. Comparable sales at US Walmart stores rose 4.1 per cent during the three-month period ended April 30. Walmart's US online sales rose 26 per cent, the company said.

Walmart's promise of lower prices, improved merchandise and faster delivery has also attracted wealthier shoppers. The biggest gains in market share for Walmart are coming from house-



holds with annual incomes over USD 100,000. That shift is taking place as lower-income shoppers become more entrenched in what economists collectively call a K-

shaped economy.

"Our results reflect our continued focus on delivering across the enterprise - better shopping experiences, a broader assortment, and faster

delivery," CEO John Furner said in a prepared statement Thursday.

Yet US retailers have spent months navigating an uncertain economic environment, from President Donald Trump's tariffs to the impact of soaring gasoline prices due to the war. The average price for a gallon of regular gasoline raced higher this week and did so again overnight. Gasoline prices are about 45 per cent above where they were at this time last year.

Based on quarterly financial reports this week from Walmart, as well as Target, Home Depot, Lowe's and TJX, shoppers are cautious but still spending, helped by more generous tax refunds. Yet there is a widespread belief among economists that once of those refunds dry up, shoppers

will pull back on spending. Consumer spending is the dominant economic engine for the US

Target reported the largest jump in comparable sales in four years on Wednesday, but a cautious outlook overshadowed convincing evidence that changes under the company's new CEO are resonating with customers. Target raised its annual revenue outlook on Wednesday, but even that falls below the pace of its first quarter this year.

The nation's two largest home improvement retailers, Home Depot and Lowe's, this week reported strong sales, but both companies said that customers are putting off larger home projects.

"I think, overall, this has been the most difficult housing market that I've faced in this business

since the financial crisis," Lowe's CEO Marvin Ellison said this week.

Walmart, based in Bentonville, Arkansas, reported first-quarter earnings of USD 5.33 billion, or 67 cents, for the quarter ended April 30. Adjusted per-share results were 66 cents, matching the 66 cents that analysts expected, according to FactSet.

For the year-ago quarter, the company reported net income of USD 4.48 billion, or 56 cents per share. Sales rose 7.3 per cent to USD 177.75 billion in the fiscal first quarter, above the USD 174.84 billion that analysts predicted.

For the second quarter, Walmart expects sales to be 4 per cent to 5 per cent higher than the same period a year ago. That brings the range to between USD 182.8 billion and USD 184.59 billion.

PROSPECT



Telangana Congress spokesperson Bandi Sudhakar Goud on Wednesday called on newly appointed Kerala Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan at his residence in Thiruvananthapuram. Bandi expressed confidence that under Satheesan's dynamic leadership, the UDF Government will successfully implement all election promises and work towards the overall development of Kerala in all aspects.

ITC Q4 profit at ₹5,469.74 cr, revenue at ₹23,821.48 cr



Diversified entity ITC Ltd on Thursday reported a consolidated profit of ₹5,018.45 crore in the quarter ended March 31, 2026. The company had posted a consolidated profit of ₹19,807.88 crore in the January-March quarter a year ago, according to a regulatory filing from the Kolkata-headquartered company. ITC's revenue from the sale of products stood at ₹21,463.36 crore in the March quarter. Its revenue from operations was at ₹21,694.67 crore. The company, which has completed the amalgamation of Wimco and Sresta Natural Bioproducts from respective appointed April 1, 2025, said its results are not comparable. "The carrying value of assets and liabilities of Wimco as appearing in the Consolidated Financial Statements of the Company and the fair value of assets and liabilities of Sresta have been recorded in accordance... Accordingly, the financial results of the Company and 'FMCG - Others' segment include those of Sresta from 13th June, 2025 and consequently are not comparable with previous periods," said ITC. Its expenses were at ₹17,348.38 crore in the March quarter of FY 26.

For the entire FY26, ITC's net profit was at ₹2,1018.15 crore. Its total consolidated income was at ₹92,339.13 crore for the financial year ended on March 31, 2026.

The board of the company has also declared a final dividend of ₹8 per share, which includes an interim dividend of ₹6.50 per share paid on February 27, 2026. Total dividend for the financial year ended March 31, 2026 amounts to ₹14.50 per share.

Shares of ITC on Thursday settled at ₹308 per scrip on BSE, down 0.15 per cent from the previous close.



KANISHK CHAUDHRY

Is the year slipping away, or is it we who quietly slip through the year, unnoticed even by ourselves?

There is something pleasantly strange about the time when we move from one year to another. Fireworks fade, greetings come to rest, calendars are replaced, and the world begins to move forward impatiently. Yet somewhere within this movement, a distinct feeling anchors within us, which is a sort of a personal ritual of turning inward.

It arrives while opening an old notebook and finding a sentence highlighted with unusual conviction or during a late-night scroll through photographs in our phones, when the early months begin to look distant, as if they belonged to another version of ourselves. Sometimes it comes simply as an uneasy feeling that time may have moved with greater sincerity than we ourselves managed to.

The promises we made at the beginning of the year, be it to live with more discipline; to become calmer; to write regularly; to be less distracted and more available in the moment, now stand, more like questions, staring right back at us. Perhaps we make these promises because somewhere we know that a meaningful life is not always destroyed by one great tragedy. More often, it is slowly diminished through habitual inattentiveness.

Why do we make such promises each year? A "year", after all, is not really a thing in nature. The Earth completes an orbit around the Sun and the rhythm is largely repeated. From that recurring movement, we create a unit stable enough to organise memory and expectation.

Nature keeps evolving, galaxies continue moving outward as they do but human beings gather under fireworks, trying to believe that beginnings can be scheduled.

Strangely, the closer science looks at time, the less it resembles the thing we claim to "have", "waste", "save" or "lose". It begins to look less like a possession and more like an experience. We do not feel relativity in equations. We feel it when childhood seems both yesterday or

another lifetime; when a year disappears in routine but one afternoon remains vivid forever. Physics may tell us that time bends with gravity, but life teaches us that it also bends with grief, love, waiting and attention.

A shattered glass does not reassemble itself. Childhood cannot be revisited except through memory. Words, once spoken, continue living in consequence even after their sound has vanished. Physics calls this the arrow of time i.e. the movement towards entropy and irreversibility. Life, too, has such an arrow. Moments, once lived, cannot be recovered in their original form. That is why years feel peculiar in hindsight.

And intensity is measured by questions such as, did we live the year attentively, or merely pass through it? Were we truly present, or mostly elsewhere, rushing toward some future moment which, once reached, vanished into another anticipation? Perhaps the real tragedy is not that time passes, but that so much of it passes un-lived. The mind remains busy preparing for life instead of inhabiting it. This is where time is most distorted i.e. not in clocks or calen-

dars, but in consciousness. One part of us rehearses the future; another revisits the past. The present becomes only a corridor we cross, without ever fully arriving.

Modern life has made this disappearance easier. Every silence now arrives with discomfort. Every idle moment seeks occupation. Information accumulates, but little settles into understanding. Attention is a scarce resource. What we repeatedly attend to shapes our neural pathways, strengthens habits and gradually constructs our identity. Behavioural psychology tells us that habits are not sustained by declarations, but by cues, repetitions and rewards. Resolutions fail so often not because people are insincere, but because they mistake desire for design.

That is why becoming an entirely "new person" every year feels artificial. Human beings do not transform through declarations. The self is not replaced overnight; it is carried forward. We are not erased and rewritten. We are revised incrementally.

Everytime we honestly look back in time, we are greeted not by pride or regret, but by humility. Humility, not because everything

goes according to plans, but because very little does. Years are not fair in their distributions. With this humility we realise that whatever goodness has endured in life isn't entirely a work of the self. It infact arrives through others, through their patience and forgiveness that does not humiliate, and through people who continue recognising possibility in us when we ourselves have lost faith.

Well, it is true that each pause in time brings the temptation of reinvention. New year, new self. There is nothing wrong with this impulse. It shows that the mind still wishes to rise.

So for each pause, whenever we choose to have it, I pray may we keep showing up.

And above all, may we live in a way that feels true from within. Because in the end, truth is the only measure that does not fluctuate. It is the only evidence that remains when applause fades, when plans fail, when calendars change and when the noise of the world grows quiet enough for us to finally hear ourselves.

Disclaimer: The views expressed are personal and are intended only as reflections on life, time and human experience.

Banks must compete on customer experience to stay relevant: EY report

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Banks will have to compete on the quality of the customer experience to remain relevant and physical branches will continue to play a strategic role, evolving into phygital advisory hubs that blend digital tools with human reassurance, EY India said in a report.

The EY report 'Customer Experience Reimagined: The New Frontier for Indian Banking in 2026' also said that banks are no longer judged only on how seamlessly

customers can transact, but on how intelligently and intuitively they anticipate needs, simplify decisions and deliver support at the exact moment it matters.

"This future will be shaped by a partnership between people, AI agents and phygital touchpoints, all working together to create experiences that feel relevant, secure and human," the report said.

The report said that customer experience (CX) in Indian banking is entering a defining inflexion point where technology, human behaviour, and contextual intelli-



gence converge.

As AI takes over transactional workflows, human advisors can focus on high-value guidance-long-term planning, life-event support and trust-building conversations, it added.

In its survey of 2,030 banking customers across diverse demographics, the report found that 70 per cent of Indian customers feel financially understood by their banks, yet gaps in service speed and clarity persist. It also found that AI-driven personalisation is gaining traction, and despite the relatively strong mobile adoption, chatbots remain underutilised and less trusted.

EY India, National Financial Services Leader, Pratik Shah said banks that excel in CX, can unlock

opportunities for cross-selling and upselling, while differentiating themselves in a highly competitive market.

"Banks must balance automation with human touch to maintain empathy, overcome legacy system constraints, scale personalisation, and uphold stringent data privacy standards.

The Reserve Bank of India's recent emphasis on re-KYC completion reflects the sector's increasing focus on seamless and efficient customer engagement," Shah said.

MahaIT hosts TechMahaImpact 2026 to strengthen digital governance

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The Maharashtra Information Technology Corporation Ltd, Government of Maharashtra, in collaboration with Elets Technomedia, successfully organised the TechMahaImpact 2026 conclave in Mumbai, bringing together policymakers, technology leaders, industry representatives, and CSR stakeholders to accelerate Maharashtra's digital transformation journey.

The conclave was inaugurated by Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis in the august presence of Deputy Chief Minister Sunetra Pawar.

During the event, 24 Memorandums of Understanding (MoUs) were signed, mobilising CSR partnerships worth ₹155.75 crore for various citizen-centric digital and social impact initiatives across the state.

The conclave highlighted Maharashtra's commitment to leveraging advanced digital platforms such as



Maha Sarathi and Aaple Sarkar to strengthen governance delivery, transparency, accessibility, and citizen empowerment.

The event also reinforced

the State's vision of building a digitally inclusive and future-ready Maharashtra under the broader mission of "Viksit Maharashtra 2047."

Inaugurating the event, CM

Devendra Fadnavis said, "Maharashtra is one state which generates the highest amount of CSR funds. Most of these funds are deployed for meaningful activities. It has been our endeavour to see that these impactful deployments happen across the geographies in Maharashtra. Through platforms like TechMahaImpact, we are ensuring that technology, innovation, and CSR partnerships come together to create real grassroots-level impact and strengthen inclusive

Central Bank of India organises grand mega retail credit outreach programme

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Central Bank of India organised a grand "Retail Credit Outreach Programme" under its Delhi North Region with the objective of promoting retail banking and providing quick financial assistance to customers. During the programme, sanction letters amounting to ₹123 crore were distributed to 114 customers under various retail loan schemes.

The chief guest of the programme was E Ratan Kumar, executive director, Central Office, Mumbai. In his address, he stated that the Central Bank of India remains continuously committed to delivering customer-centric banking, quick loan approvals, and digital banking services to every section of society. He



urged customers to take advantage of the bank's various retail schemes and become active participants in economic growth.

During the programme, Tarsem Singh Zira, zonal head, Delhi, said that the bank's objective is to provide customers with simple, transparent, and prompt banking services, while supporting their housing, vehicle, education, and personal needs through retail loans. He added that the programme is an important initiative towards strengthening trust and relationships between the bank and its customers.

GOC-in-C Eastern Command reviews Op Preparedness of Red Shield Division

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

Lieutenant General VMB Krishnan, PVSM, AVSM, YSM, Army Commander, Eastern Command, reviewed the operational preparedness of the Red Shield Division of the Army's Spear Corps on May 20.

He also visited the Red Shield Drone Lab at Leimakhong Military Station to assess strides made in indigenous unmanned aerial systems (UAS) technology and specialised combat training. The Army Commander was briefed on trailblazing initiatives in localised drone assembly, servicing, and overhauling ecosystems, effectively mitigating external supply chain dependencies.

He also witnessed live demonstrations of customised, mission-specific platforms engineered to dominate the region's complex terrain and peculiar



operational dynamics. A cornerstone of this initiative remains the technical empowerment of vanguard personnel through structured modules, equipping troops with niche technology to operate and maintain these advanced assets under adverse field conditions.

This enterprise underscores the unwavering commitment toward the ethos of 'Atmanirbhar Bharat', ensuring frontline formations remain a lethal, self-reliant, and future-ready force capable of neutralising evolving modern security challenges.

REC Foundation signs MoA with LLRM Medical College to strengthen healthcare access in Meerut

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Reinforcing its commitment towards making healthcare accessible to the last mile, the CSR arm of REC Limited, REC Foundation, signed a Memorandum of Agreement (MoA) with Lalaji Prasad Memorial (LLRM) Medical College on May 21, 2026, for providing doorstep primary healthcare services to deprived and underserved sections of society in Meerut



district of Uttar Pradesh.

The signing ceremony was graced by Arun Govil, MP, and Ramesh Gupta, Principal, LLRM Medical College, along

with senior officials of REC including TSC Bosh, Director (Projects); Rajesh Kumar, Director (Finance); Arun Kumar Tyagi, Executive Director (CSR); and Bhupesh Chandolia, HOD (CSR).

Under the agreement, REC Foundation has committed financial assistance of ₹1.20 crore towards the procurement and deployment of one Mobile Medical Unit (MMU), including its operational expenditure for a period of three years.

The Mobile Medical Unit will play a vital role in delivering essential healthcare services to remote and underserved communities, ensuring timely medical assistance for individuals who otherwise have limited access to healthcare facilities.

Through such focused CSR initiatives, REC Foundation continues to contribute towards inclusive development and strengthening healthcare infrastructure across the country.

DAILY SUDOKU

578

538

87

152

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction-no maths involved.

SOLUTION (21.5.26)

274863195

358917462

961542783

796381254

813425679

425679831

587234916

632198547

149756328

DOUBLE CROSSWORD

FRIDAY | MAY 22, 2026

ACROSS

1 Angry enough to change sides? (5)

6 A sound sort of mixture (5)

9 Thomas is said to have a fan, it appears (7)

10 Corner of a chine? (5)

11 Find real chaos at the detention centre (5)

12 A competitive egg carrier! (5)

13 Disorder due to 1001 new rules (7)

15 Father's step across the Channel (3)

17 A bit concerned? Singularly! (4)

18 Having very little money about me, can be sticky (6)

19 In law, some allegations can be doubtful (5)

20 Give an elevating talk for flirtatious purposes? (4,2)

22 Being a goody-goody, is less than sprightly (4)

24 A joint, but it could be fruit (3)

25 Look long at a lordly list (7)

26 Bonehead! (5)

27 Twice the profit on an article (5)

28 Any number intruding can be a nuisance (5)

29 Saint or doctor taking in a little one (7)

30 Crooked as that place near Richmond (5)

31 Make allusion in freer style (5)

DOWN

2 Though dried, is covered in water! (6)

3 The all round starting price, in this case (6)

4 The washerwoman? Not her! (3)

5 Shoot out of sight (5)

6 Officer needing some help with a bit of punctuation (7)

7 Does it mean nothing to males? (4)

8 Silver tongue? (6)

12 Rest a little while in early September (5)

13 Hang around with a low companion (5)

14 A bit of a fight (5)

15 Ancient city part destroyed out East (5)

16 The boards put on rickety gates (5)

18 It's a fawn, this animal (5)

19 Where to make one's fortune immediately? (7)

21 They're made to turn (6)

22 Personage for whom public relations can be nice (6)

23 Pass over a wild region (6)

25 Flat area suitable for an aircraft take-off? (5)

26 Sort of saddle for a team event? (4)

28 A tune that's very good and never ends (3)

29 Swats

21. Hal-MA

23. Pla-in-Ly

24. Co Down

25. Eire

27. Otter

28. Bites

9. Ram

30. Cheap

32. F-ear

33. Cee

24. Get well

26. Tom-boy

29. AKA (rev.)

31. S-t-aid

32. Fr-eight

34. To-Ned

35. Nee

36. Bec-EW

37. CL-ear

38. Snark

1. Dig up

2. Des-pair

4. Li-es

5. Star-b-le

6. Hello

7. Close

9. Ram

12. Pr-esle-y

14. E-rr

16. Awf-U-I

17. T-Ruth

19. Stewa-R-d

BRIEFLY

Ashmita moves to quarterfinals of Malaysia Masters



Ashmita Chaliha moved to the women's singles quarterfinals, emerging as the country's lone surviving contender after the rest of the Indian challenge came to an end at the Malaysia Masters Super 500 tournament here on Thursday.

Ashmita registered a comfortable 21-13, 21-16 victory over Malaysia's Goh Jin Wei in the pre-quarterfinals, wrapping up the contest in under 30 minutes with a composed all-round display.

Kjaersfeldt advanced after defeating India's Malvika Bansod, who squandered a one-game advantage to go down 21-16, 8-21, 15-21 in a 59-minute battle.

In another women's singles clash, reigning Thailand Masters champion Devika Sihag was outclassed by top seed Chen Yufei of China, who sealed a 21-16, 21-13 win in 36 minutes. (PTI)

Southampton lose appeal against play-off expulsion



Southampton's appeal against its expulsion from the Championship playoff final because of spying offenses was dismissed. An arbitration panel on Wednesday upheld the English Football League's decision to remove Southampton from Saturday's final, meaning Middlesbrough will take its place and play Hull at Wembley Stadium for the chance to win promotion to the Premier League.The decision is final.

Southampton was expelled on Tuesday after admitting to repeatedly spying on opponents.

It was charged earlier this month for the unauthorised filming of Middlesbrough's practice sessions ahead of their semifinal. It went on to win the two-legged tie to go within one game of promotion to the top flight.

The southeast club subsequently admitted further breaches this season concerning games against Oxford United and Ipswich. It was also deducted four points for next season.

In its appeal, it described its punishment as "manifestly disproportionate" to any previous sanction in English soccer history. (AP)

Commonwealth Games Day celebrations in India on May 24

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

Shooter Anjum Modgil and badminton player Trupti Murgunde will be among the sporting stars in attendance when the country celebrates the Commonwealth Games Day on May 24 across 8,000 locations with the main event in Ahmedabad.

The 75th edition of Fit India Sundays on Cycle will be organised in Ahmedabad on May 24 "in the spirit of the Commonwealth Games movement, celebrating sportsmanship, unity, fitness and national pride", the sports ministry stated on Thursday.

Sports Minister Mansukh Mandaviya, along with Gujarat Deputy Chief Minister Harsh Sanghavi, will lead the event in Ahmedabad.

"The theme for this edition, 'A New Icon for a Fitter India — Pedalling to 2030', reflects the vision of preparing India for CWG 2030 through fitness, unity and sporting spirit."

A special CWG-themed exhibition will also be inaugurated during the event, showcasing India's sporting achievements over the last 12 years, alongside flagship schemes such as the Khelo India Mission and Sports Goods Manufacturing initiatives.

Actor Ayushmann Khurrana, along with former Commonwealth medal-



lists, including Rajani Etimarpu (Hockey), Gurjit Kaur (Hockey), Sonika Tandi (Hockey), Ankur Mittal (Shooting), Murgunde and Modgil (Shooting), as well as thousands of cyclists, will participate in the event.

"Union Ministers, State Ministers, MPs and public representatives will participate in their respective regions, further strengthening Sports Jan Bhagidari across the country," the min-

istry said. In the run-up to the CWG Day celebration, a nationwide quiz competition, reel-making contest and torch design competition were organised on the MY Bharat platform, which saw participation from more than one lakh youngsters.

Fit India Sundays on Cycle has so far reached 3.07 lakh locations across 74 editions, with participation by over 50 lakh cyclists.

Aston Villa celebrates Europa League triumph

JAMES ROBSONAP ■ Istanbul

In front of the future king of England, Unai Emery reaffirmed his status as the king of the Europa League. Aston Villa beat Freiburg 3-0 in Istanbul on Wednesday to secure Emery a record-extending fifth title in this competition.

Celebrating wildly inside the Tupras Stadium was lifelong Villa fan Prince William, who traveled to watch his beloved team end a 30-year wait for a major trophy. "Amazing night!! Huge congratulations to all the players, team, staff and everyone connected to the club!" the Prince posted on X.

He had his phone out taking photos as captain John McGinn lifted the cup in the center of the field and in front of an explosion of confetti. "He's a classy guy. He was in the dressing room before the game and he's a



massive Villa fan so he was never going to miss it," McGinn told TNT Sports.

It was Villa's first major piece of silverware since winning the English League Cup in 1996 and its first continental title since lifting the European Cup and then the Super Cup in 1982.

Was the outcome ever in doubt with the ultimate Europa League specialist

Emery on the sideline? The Spanish coach has enjoyed remarkable success in Europe's second-tier competition, winning it three years running with Sevilla from 2014-16 and again with Villarreal in 2021.

Now he has led a third team with Villa' in its name to the title. "I am always very grateful for Europe, for every competition, Conference

League, Champions League, Europa League, but especially Europa League," Emery said. "We fought strongly in this competition and tried to give it our best. We played in a very serious way this year."

2 brilliant first-half strikes from Youri Tielemans and Emiliano Buendia put Villa into a 2-0 lead at the break. Morgan Rogers added a third in the second half. (AP)

Praggnanandhaa held by Deac Bogdan-Daniel

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Bucharest (Romania)

Indian Grandmaster R Praggnanandhaa was held to a draw by Romanian Deac Bogdan-Daniel while France's Alireza Firouzja decided to finally call it quits in the sixth round of the Super Chess Classic, part of the Grand Chess Tour.

Alireza, who played two games despite an ankle injury, decided it was not possible for him to continue and withdrew on the rest day of the ten-players nine-rounds tournament.

Germany's Vincent Keymer was the one to benefit from Firouzja's withdrawal as he



stretched his lead to a full point after getting a walk over in this round.

While all the other games ended in draws, Keymer remained as the sole leader on 4.5 points, a full point clear of Holland's Jorden Van

Foreest and Anish Giri, top seeded American Fabiano Caruana and Praggnanandhaa who all have 3.5 point each.

Maxime Vachier-Lagrave of France and Wesley share the sixth spot on three points

apiece while World Championship challenger Javokhir Sindarov of Uzbekistan is close behind on 2.5 points. Romanian Deac Bogdan-Daniel is in ninth spot with two points and Firouzja ended his campaign on one point from five games.

Deac Bogdan-Daniel might be the lowest ranked but the Romanian has time and again proved why he is the local pick for the main event as a wild card.

Praggnanandhaa went for complications right from the opening by going for the Stonewall Dutch but Deac did not flinch and matched the Indian move-for-move.

Diksha Dagar aims to go one better in Morocco

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Dar es Salam (Morocco)

A year after losing in play-off, India's Diksha Dagar is back to challenge for the Lalla Meryem Cup in Morocco, hoping to go one better after a runner-up finish in the last edition. The two-time LET winner, Diksha is being accompanied by Pranavi Urs, Avani Prashanth and Hitaashee Bakshi this week.

A year ago, Cara Gainer of England shot a final round of 4-under 69 to get into a play-off where she claimed a clutch victory defeating Diksha in a sudden-death playoff to secure her maiden win on the LET at Royal Golf Dar Es Salam.



Interestingly both Gainer and Diksha will have their fathers as their caddies this week. Gainer was helped by fiancée, Seb, last year as he caddied for her en route to victory. This year it will be her father as she defends the Lalla

Meryem Cup. Also having her Dad on the bag will be Diksha, whose father, Col. Narender, is regular as caddie for her.

Diksha will be playing with Lina Belmati of Morocco and Emma Spitz of Austria, while Pranavi plays with

Patricia Isabel Schmidt of Germany and Luca Thompson of Wales. Avani goes out with Maria Hernandez of Spain and Lisa Pettersson of Sweden and Hitaashee is grouped with Hannah Screen of England and Andrea Lignell.

All four Indian girls are geared towards the second half of the season, which will include their home event, the Hero Women's Indian Open, where all of them have finished in Top-5 but never won.

Maha Haddioui is all smiles ahead of this week's Lalla Meryem Cup as the home favourite welcomes her tour mates to Morocco.

Scheffler looks for putting rebound

SCHUYLER DIXONAP ■ McKinney (USA)

Scottie Scheffler is eager to test the difficulty of the revamped greens at the CJ Cup Byron Nelson a year after tying the PGA Tour's 72-hole scoring record while winning his hometown event by eight shots.

The world's top-ranked player doesn't exactly have momentum on his side going into Thursday's start at TPC Craig Ranch in suburban Dallas, given how putting kept him from making a run as the defending champion at the PGA Championship last week.

"Overall, I feel like I'm in a good spot," Scheffler said. "I've actually putted the best that I have in my career so far this year and just kind of get a reset, get on some new greens, work on my reads, make sure I'm checking all my fundamentals."

The Lanny Wadkins-led redesign of the par-71 layout, at a cost of nearly \$25 million, focused mostly on new bent-grass greens with more contours. Additional bunkers



helped transform the fairways as well.

Undulating greens were a big part of the PGA story at Aronimink, where Scheffler couldn't make a run to contention Sunday after missing a 4-foot birdie putt early and two par putts that were even shorter on the back nine. He

ended up tied for 14th. Scheffler said he has been reminded of last summer, when a rough time on the greens left him tied for eighth at the Scottish Open before he huddled with putting coach Phil Kenyon and won his first British Open the next week. (AP)

CTC keen to fast-track reforms in Sri Lanka Cricket



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Colombo

The Cricket Transformation Committee (CTC), the Government-appointed interim panel tasked with running Sri Lanka Cricket, on Thursday made it clear that it intends to amend the SLC constitution governing the election of office-bearers.

The CTC addressed the media here for the first time since being appointed by the country's sports minister. "We want to do it as fast as possible," CTC chairman Erani Wickremaratna said.

Wickremaratna, a former junior minister, said the entire process, including parliamentary procedures, would take

at least six months. Asked about the visit of officials Imran Khwaja and Devajit Saikia, Wickremaratna said the world body had been "very cordial and constructive", but declined to reveal whether the ICC had specified a timeframe for the CTC's functioning.

"The ICC knows we are open and transparent with what we are doing," he said. Asked what was wrong with the existing system of electing office-bearers, Wickremaratna said: "There are lots of concerns that have come up about the current constitution. The so-called democratic voting system seems to have been abused in a big way."

Ketan Kushwaha to captain India team in U18 Asia Cup

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Bhopal

Forward Ketan Kushwaha was on Thursday appointed captain of the Indian team for the upcoming U18 Asia Cup from May 29 to June 6 in Kakamigahara, Japan.

The squad was selected after a rigorous national coaching camp at Udhav Das Mehta (Bhai ji) Central Centre at SAI Bhopal under the team's coaching staff comprising Sardar Singh and Rajnish Mishra.

The team's preparations included a high-profile four-match series against the Australia U-18 team in Bhopal as part of an exposure tour. Gearing up for the tournament, the Indian team won one match against Australia U18 and lost one. Two matches ended up as drawn affairs.

Commenting on the final squad for the tournament, coach Sardar said, "The selection process was



incredibly competitive, but we have picked an 18-member squad that gives us the perfect tactical balance.

"Our training in Bhopal and the exposure matches against a top-tier side like Australia gave these boys a great understanding of international pressure and match tempo. We have spent the last few weeks working heavily on our tactical discipline, penalty corner routines, and structure.

"The boys are in high spirits; and going into a major tournament like the Asia Cup, our objective is

clear - we want to execute our plans effectively, top our group and put ourselves in the best possible position to bring home the trophy," he added.

India has been drawn in Pool A alongside South Korea, hosts Japan, Chinese Taipei, and Kazakhstan.

The Indian team will kick off their pool-stage campaign on May 29 against Kazakhstan, before taking on hosts Japan on May 31.

They will then face South Korea on June 1 and wrap up their group matches against Chinese Taipei on June 3.

GT eliminates CSK from IPL play-offs race

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Ahmedabad

Gujarat Titans' bankable top order laid the groundwork for a dominating 89-run win over Chennai Super Kings here on Thursday, taking them closer to a top-two qualification for the Indian Premier League play-offs.

Shubman Gill (64 off 37) and Sai Sudharsan (84 off 53) added to their remarkable consistency as an opening pair with a record seventh century partnership, fuelling Gujarat Titans to 229 for four on a true batting surface.

Jos Buttler (57 not out off 27) blasted a barrage of sixes and fours in the second half of the innings to prop up the total.

CSK, who had a slim chance of making the play-offs going into this must-win game, lost the match in the powerplay when they lost four wickets for 51 runs. The visitors'

were all out for 140 in 13.4 overs after a six filled cameo from Shivam Dube (47 off 17).

For the third straight season, the five-time champions failed to make the play-offs.

Mohammed Siraj took three wickets in the first six overs, including that of Sanju Samson, who edged the very first delivery of the CSK innings. Samson fished at a wide delivery and got a faint tickle on way to Buttler.

Titans' bowling unit has arguably been the best in the tournament and they reinforced with a stellar show in the first six overs. Complementing Siraj, Kagiso Rabada had Matthew Short at mid on off a ball that seamed back in slightly and the Australia could not connect properly. Titans capped of their successful stage campaign with nine wins in 14 matches, totalling 18 points. Sunrisers



Hyderabad too can reach 18 points if they win against Royal Challengers Bengaluru, who are already on 18 points, tomorrow.

The top two sides out of four play-

left arm pacer Spencer Johnson in the powerplay.

Gill got his fifty off 23 balls while Sudharsan reached the milestone off 35 balls, his fifth consecutive half-century. Gill scored the bulk of the runs in their 125-run stand off 74 balls. The range of boundaries Gill picked up off a wayward Johnson was a masterclass in batting. He mixed minimum muscle with trademark elegance to get the desired results.

His fours off Johnson included a cut off the Australian's very first ball before the Indian star used his crease against the left-arm pacer to collect boundaries at will. The straight drive in the same over was the most majestic of them all.

When Noor Ahmad was brought into the attack post powerplay that yielded 62 runs, Gill did not allow him to settle, slog sweeping him for couple of sixes.

National Anti-Doping Act set to be amended



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

The recently-amended National Anti Doping Act will be modified once again to criminalise trafficking and distribution of prohibited substances to athletes with a jail term of upto five years for suppliers, targeting even medical practitioners if they knowingly prescribe banned drugs.

The amendments have been uploaded on the Sports Ministry's website for requisite feedback from the public with the deadline for submission being June 18. Sports Minister Mansukh Mandaviya said the amended bill will be tabled during the upcoming monsoon session of the Parliament after taking the feedback into consideration.

"Whoever administers or applies to an athlete, for the purpose of or in connection with doping in sport...shall be punishable with imprisonment for a term which may extend to (five) years, or with fine which may extend up to (two lakh) rupees, or both," the proposed amendment States.

DISCUS THROWER BANVIR BANNED FOR 7 YEARS

Discus thrower Banvir Singh has been banned for seven years by the National Anti-Doping Agency's Appeal Panel (ADAP) for flunking a dope test, adding two years to the punishment handed out to him by the Disciplinary Committee.

Last year, NADA's Anti-Doping Disciplinary Panel (ADDP) had suspended Singh for five years effective from December 23, 2024 testing positive for steroid methandienone.

He was also serving a two-year ineligibility period until December 22 this year for three whereabouts failures within 12 months.

AB de Villiers joins hands with AI coaching platform Kabuni



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

Kabuni, an AI-powered sports technology platform, appointed former South Africa skipper AB de Villiers as one of its "Super Coaches" on Thursday.

De Villiers thus joins previously-revealed Super Coaches former India captain Sourav Ganguly and ex Australia all-rounder Shane Watson.

"This collaboration brings together Kabuni's cutting-edge technology with AB de Villiers' deep cricketing expertise, creating a powerful blend of data-driven insights and real-world experience for aspiring cricketers," Kabuni said in a statement.

Fans aged 12-16 years in India will be able to compete for a chance to play for de Villiers' team though a new nationwide tournament launching in June, utilising Kabuni's technology.

"Cricket has always been about expression for me, finding new ways to solve problems and push the limits of what's possible. What Kabuni is building is incredibly exciting because it gives young players a platform to explore their game, trust their instincts, and develop in a way that feels natural to them," de Villiers said.

Kabuni's platform is designed to transform traditional net practice by capturing player movement and ball tracking in real time, translating it into simple, actionable feedback. With its unique "1% improvement" approach, the system focuses on small, immediate corrections that lead to meaningful performance gains over time.

RCB seek top-place finish as SRH chase Qualifier 1 berth

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Hyderabad

Defending champions Royal Challengers Bengaluru and Sunrisers Hyderabad will both be eyeing a top-two finish when they square off in their final IPL league match here on Friday.

RCB currently sit atop the points table with 18 points and the best net run rate (NRR) of 1.065 among the 10 teams. A victory on Friday would guarantee them a first-place finish and two opportunities to reach the final.

Sunrisers Hyderabad, meanwhile, are placed third with 16 points from 13 matches, level with Gujarat Titans but behind on NRR. SRH have an NRR



of 0.350 compared to GT's 0.400 and their best chance of breaking into the top two would be to beat RCB convincingly and hope Chennai Super Kings defeat GT.

RCB have once again enjoyed an outstanding campaign under skipper Rajat Patidar, blending explosive batting with disciplined bowling to emerge as title contenders for the second successive season.

The talismanic Virat Kohli has continued to redefine consistency at the top of the order, collecting 542 runs from 13 matches, while Devdutt Padikkal has also enjoyed a good season.

The experienced pace duo of Bhuvneshwar Kumar and Josh Hazlewood has also played a pivotal role in RCB's success. Bhuvneshwar has been among the leading wicket-takers this season, making the new ball talk regularly, while Hazlewood has delivered impactful spells at crucial moments.

Krunal Pandya too has impressed with his all-round value, troubling batters with subtle variations. Leg-spinner Suyash Sharma and all-rounder Romario Shepherd have also done their bit.

Anukul Roy added to India A squad for Sri Lanka tri-series

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

All-rounder Anukul Roy was on Thursday added to the India A squad for the upcoming tri-series in Sri Lanka, replacing Harsh Dubey who received a maiden call-up to the senior Test and ODI squads.

A left-handed batsman and a left-arm spin bowler, Roy has represented Jharkhand in domestic cricket and plays for Kolkata Knight Riders in the IPL.

"The men's selection committee has added Anukul Roy to the India A squad for the upcoming tri-series in Sri Lanka. He replaces Harsh Dubey, who has received his maiden call-up to India's Test and ODI squads for the upcoming IDFC First Bank home series against Afghanistan," the BCCI said in statement.

Roy first rose to prominence as the joint-highest wicket-taker (14 wickets) during India's victori-



ous 2018 ICC Under-19 World Cup campaign. The upcoming tri-series will feature Sri Lanka A, India A and Afghanistan A, and will be played in Dambulla from June 9 to June 21. Captained by Tilak Varma with Riyan Parag as his deputy, the youthful 15-member squad features prominent IPL talents, including Priyansh Arya, Ayush Badoni, Prabhsimran Singh, and Yash Thakur.

Teenage batting prodigy

Vaibhav Sooryavanshi has also been named in the squad.

Updated India A squad for tri-series: Tilak Varma (Captain), Priyansh Arya, Vaibhav Sooryavanshi, Riyan Parag (Vice-Captain), Ayush Badoni, Nishant Sindhu, Suryansh Shedge, Prabhsimran Singh (WK), Kumar Kushagra (WK), Vipraj Nigam, Yash Thakur, Yudhvir Singh, Anshul Kamboj, Arshad Khan, Anukul Roy.

Hardik Pandya fined 10 per cent of match fee

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Kolkata

Mumbai Indians captain Hardik Pandya has been fined 10 per cent of his match fee and handed one demerit point for abuse of cricket equipment after he forcefully knocked the bails of the wicket during a frustrating spell in the IPL match against Kolkata Knight Riders.

Pandya was found to have breached Level 1 of the Code as he "knocked the bails of the wicket with force while walking back to his run-up" during the match that MI lost by four wickets at the Eden Gardens here on Wednesday.

KKR chased down the target of 148 with seven balls to spare, and Pandya returned wicket-less from his two overs while conceding 13 runs.



"Hardik Pandya was found to have breached Article 2.2 of the IPL's Code of Conduct, which pertains to 'abuse

of cricket equipment or clothing, ground equipment or fixtures and fittings during a Match,'" the IPL said in a statement.

"The incident occurred on the fourth ball of the 10th over of the second innings of the match, when Hardik Pandya, while walking back to his run-up, knocked the bails of the wicket with force."

Accumulation of four to seven demerit points leads to a one-match suspension in the IPL.

Pandya admitted to the offence and accepted the sanction imposed by Match Referee Rajiv Seth.

Five-time champions MI are already out of contention for a place in the IPL play-offs this year after enduring a horrendous season during which they have won only four games.

IPA to select Indian junior pickleball team through trials

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Ahmedabad

The Indian Pickleball Association (IPA) and the Sports Authority of India (SAI) will conduct trials here next month to select the Indian team for the upcoming Pickleball World Cup in Vietnam.

"The junior squad for the Indian pickleball contingent is extremely vital as it determines the players that will represent India on the global stage for many years to come. These are the



players that will potentially one day compete at the major global events once pickleball officially enters those events as well.

"The World Cup is the perfect starting point for

the young talent across India to showcase their skills or compete alongside the best junior talent in the world," said Suryaveer Singh Bhullar, President, Indian Pickleball Association.

Dave Cousins to join India as compound chief coach

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Kolkata

With an eye on the Los Angeles Olympics where compound archery will make its debut, India have appointed multiple-time former world champion Dave Cousins as their chief compound coach, with the American set to join within two weeks ahead of the Stage 3 World Cup in Antalya next month.

This will be the first international coaching assignment for the 49-year-old, who has previously coached clubs and state teams in the USA besides enjoying an illustrious competitive career spanning more than two decades.

Compound archery will make its long-awaited Olympic debut at LA 2028



with only a mixed team event, and the Archery Association of India believes Cousins fits perfectly into its long-term plans.

The appointment, however, came after prolonged negotiations with former coach and Italian legend Sergio Pagni

failed to materialise. The development was confirmed to PTI by AAI treasurer Dr Joris Paulose Ummacheril.

"Yes, he has been finalised as the compound coach and we have some paperwork formalities to complete," Dr Ummacheril said.

Nitish unlocks pace potential: All-rounder bumps up pace

G UNNIKRISHNAN ■ Bengaluru

When England speedster Jofra Archer became the template for refining Nitish Kumar Reddy's bowling action, the results were bound to be exhilarating.

Nitish has shown improved accuracy and a notable spike in his pace during the ongoing edition of IPL — from a trundler bowling at late 120 kmph to someone who can touch late 130 to early 140 clicks, his transformation with the ball has not gone unnoticed.

Chief selector Ajit Agarkar recently highlighted the all-rounder's improved bowling while explaining his inclusion in India's squads for the upcoming one-off Test and ODI series against Afghanistan.

"We have seen a lot of progress over the last few months with regards to his



bowling. He will be a critical part of our team if he keeps developing, especially leading to 2027 ODI WC," Agarkar had said, indicating that Nitish is not merely a like-for-like backup option for Hardik Pandya. Nitish's transformation will certainly add a lot more teeth to India's bowling attack and

how has he done it?

"It's the understanding that fast bowling is more about the brain than muscle and the brain can be trained quickly by waking it up. Nitish was a bit asleep in his bowling earlier. All I did was just to wake him up by training methods that he hadn't done before," Steffan Jones,

a renowned pace bowling coach from England, told PTI.

So, what were those training methods?

"It was a seven-day session and skill requires frequency of practice. So, we made sure that every ball he bowled was flat out. We minimised the fatigue, because when you're tired,

you're not working on speed. But it was multiple exposures of moving quickly, of bowling quickly," said Jones.

"That was the training - lots of bowling with heavy and light balls, I also kept Varun Aaron (SRH bowling coach) in the loop with all of it because I coached Varun as well for three weeks during his playing days."

Jones, who earlier worked with Rajasthan Royals as bowling coach, said some essential tweaks were to be made in Nitish's action and run-up to gain the optimum results.

"Based on the data I did with him on the Pitchwolf app, which is called a 1080 sprint, I told him that he needs to run in faster, he needs to run in from further back, because he's a hip-dominant bowler, and relies on linear momentum from his run-up."